Five Golden Rings

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/37434763.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

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Summary

After four years, Adora is back at the Olympics for a second time, only this time she isnt competing for America anymore and Catra is here too. After Catra suffered a catastrophic training accident she was forced to watch what would have been their first Games together from a hospital bed. Their relationship fell apart when Adora returned home.
Adora is hopeful that in the isolation of the Olympic village they can rekindle their friendship that has long been dead. She thinks it would be foolish to hope for more – at least, she thinks that until Catra approaches her on the first night and propositions her.
(Or, a Catradora Winter Olympics AU)

Notes

Disclaimer: Ihavent watched the Olympics in years and Idont know anything about sports in general, but Ido know the Olympic village is a fuckfest and Ihave a soft spot for Olympics AUs, so here we are. Freestyle ski (slopestyle) is my favourite winter sport, but Iknow nothing about it except that it looks cool. For this AU, the sport itself isnt the focus.
CW: somewhat graphic descriptions of sports-related injuries (including broken bones). There will also be some internalized ableist thoughts by Catra (about herself, often echoing things other people said to her) throughout the fic.

The First Night

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora sees Catra at competitions sometimes, but often they dont really get to talk. They *could*, but Catra usually tries to avoid her or only speaks to her to trade barbs. The Olympics are different. They're both staying in the Olympic Village together, and though there is enough room for Catra to dodge Adora, it is harder than when they're staying at separate hotels and thus only around each other when they are competing and need to concentrate on something other than each other.

The Olympics are also kind of where they fell apart four years ago. They were supposed to be there *together*, but Shadow was furious that Catra, who she considered a subpar athlete, had made the cut for the team and thus would be representing her on the international stage. She was an adult and their old foster-mom-slash-coach couldnt stop Catra from going to any competition that she chose, but as Catra was still under contract, Shadow drove her into the ground leading up to the events, trying to "train her up to where she needed to be"so she wouldnt *embarrass her* on the international stage.

Finally, Catra sustained a life-threatening injury during a training jump. She was still in the hospital when Adora got on the plane to go to the Games. They didnt know if she would ever ski again. Adora was devastated to go to the Olympics alone. When Angella approached Adora about switching countries, Adora took the opportunity in a heartbeat. She thought that Catra would want to come with her whether she ended up able to return to the sport or not. Their training conditions were draconian and she just wanted to get Catra somewhere better to heal.

Adora thought that making it clear that she wanted Catra to come along whether she recovered or not would show her that Adora never cared about her skiing ability but rather *her*. Instead, Catra was furious when Adora returned from the Olympics. She snarled in Adora's face about not being some stray that Adora could drag around wherever she wanted. *My career is just as important as yours, and it's here*, she said – yelled, actually. Adora started the conversation delivering what she thought was good news for both of them and it devolved into a fight that left them both crying as they yelled at each other.

Catra has moved on from Shadow's training grounds now, but she hasn't shown any signs of wanting to switch her allegiances or even speak to Adora again. Catra has missed fewer competitions due to injuries since leaving – even while dealing with the long-term effects of, among other things, her collarbone breaking severely enough to stab out through her shoulder – but she continues to treat Adora the same way that she did the day after they broke up. Her body may have healed, but it doesn't seem like her heart has.

A significant part of why Adora is excited to have made it to the Olympics again is because it's her best chance at reconnecting with Catra. She is still shocked when Catra comes sauntering up to her on the first night after the opening ceremonies.

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Adora is, as always, a golden example of an athlete. Catra watches her from the roof of her dorm with her tail twitching. Adora is across the small greenspace that the dorms of the Olympic village are built around – rumor is that the planning committee was trying to encourage spending time in larger social gatherings outside rather than in one-on-one liaisons in the dorms – laughing with Glimmer and unaware of Catra's presence. Even if it weren't for the ice

skater's pink hair, Catra would recognize her in an instant. After all, she was the one who Adora befriended four years ago to replace Catra. It was *her* mom that poached Adora too.

Catra has been waiting four years for this moment. Rivals or not, she has missed Adora – almost pathetically so – and her breath catches just being able to watch her unguarded. Catra always has to have her defenses up when she runs into Adora at competitions. She knows that it would be all too easy to fall into her arms again and she wasn't about to let that happen until she has proved herself. She earned this once and it was stolen from her. She is going to prove Shadow, and Adora, and every sportswriter who said that her career was over *wrong*.

She has had years of missing Adora to realize some things about how they parted – namely that Adora wasn't *trying* to be cruel even if it worked out that way – but she can't ignore that she spent her whole life trying to prove that she could be just as good as Adora and Adora wrote her off just as quickly as everybody else did. She didn't do it without reason given the extent of Catra's injuries, but she put her own career above Catra, expecting Catra to move to a foreign country when she was too injured to hold a *pen* just because Adora wanted to work for someone else.

She didn't have the right to be the one to decide that they should leave when *Catra* was the one who had sustained multiple injuries trying to keep up with Shadow's training regime. Shadow always worked Catra harder than Adora and then doubled down when she "failed" because she was too exhausted to perform at Adora's level on the day of a competition. If Shadow had been a little easier on Catra, she could have been neck-and-neck with Adora all her life, but instead Adora often placed above her because she was actually *well* when competitions rolled around.

Catra can admit at this point that she was projecting a lot of the things that she read online about herself onto Adora's actions, but she was in a really dark place at the time. It was the wrong place, wrong time for everything from Adora's words to their careers to just

them. Catra has been living with the consequences of her injury and their fallout for four years. She's fucking tired of it. She wants to move on, but that is never going to happen until she does her final Olympic run. Catra has already proved that she is good enough to represent America again. It was only the first hurdle, but it has already brought her some sense of peace and satisfaction.

The day that the Olympic lineup was announced, Adora tweeted congratulating her for making the cut and saying she couldn't wait for them to finally compete against each other at the Olympics. Catra hasn't spoken to her in anything other than sneers in four years, but Adora still paid attention and tried to reach out in the only way she could. An idea formed in Catra's mind that day and watching Adora now, just as radiant as she has always been, she can't think of any reason not to go through with it. They haven't even done their qualifying runs yet and there is no way to know how they will go, but Catra has finally reached the point where she knows that she either has to let go of Adora or let go of her grudge.

If she could have let go Adora, she would have done it four years ago. She carefully slips down from the roof, lowering herself down onto the first-floor awning and then hopping to the ground. Normally she would be more graceful, but she isn't taking any risks this close to the competition. It would be her luck to get a sprained ankle doing simple parkour. When she turns to look back across the lawn, she sees that Glimmer has spotted her. Her widening eyes catch Adora's attention and Adora turns around almost eagerly, like she knows exactly who Glimmer is looking at. Maybe her expression says all that it needs to.

Catra smirks at Adora – well, all her smiles are slightly lopsided now, but it's on *purpose* this time – and saunters across the grass. She watches Adora's eyes go wide, seeming shocked by Catra's approach. That's fair, honestly. Catra has never acted any differently to Adora since their fight despite her evolving thoughts and building loneliness. She just couldn't. They couldn't trade a smile until the next Olympics were behind them. If Catra hadn't made the cut-

Well, she suspects that she wouldn't be reaching out and grabbing the strap of Adora's Team Canada jacket with her left hand once she is within arms' reach, but she *did* make it, so she doesn't have to worry about how she would continue hold onto her bitterness in the worst case scenario.

"C'mon, Miss America," Catra orders Adora as she doesn't even halt her step, yanking Adora after her. Glimmer starts to protest, but Catra doesn't give a shit what the ice skater wants.

"Catra?" Adora questions, sounding hopeful and *lost* as she stumbles after her, following her despite Glimmer's hiss of *Adora, no*.

"Hey, you don't get to be an asshole for years and then just-" Glimmer starts to protest, practically jogging after them as Catra pulls them towards the dorm building that Adora and Glimmer emerged from. Catra wishes that she had grabbed Adora with her bad hand so she could flip Glimmer off, but she can't hold just one finger up on her right hand anymore, so she has to settle for scoffing.

"And you don't get to steal my fucking girlfriend and then tell her what to do. Go suck face with your boytoy for an hour and dream about meddling with someone else's life," Catra sneers back. Glimmer lets out an indignant and downright offended noise, but Adora doesn't dig in her heels and try to stop Catra from leading her on.

"*Excuse me-*" Glimmer hisses back, but Adora cuts her off this time.

"Let us talk," Adora says, her voice sounding a bit distant. Catra can't help but wonder if Adora even registered how rude she just was or if she stopped listening after *Miss America*. Catra certainly hasn't said it in anything but a sneer since she first jeered it at Adora when she was moving out. Adora has been trying to get Catra alone for years and this is the first time that Catra has reached across the gap between them for herself. Maybe that alone earns Adora's daze, but Catra doesn't know why Adora is so surprised.

After all, everybody knows what happens in the Olympic village. Four years ago, Catra was afraid Adora would find somebody else and come home with another girl's name on her lips. In a way, she did, even if she and Glimmer are platonic and Glimmer is happily married. Even if Catra was as bitter and angry as she was on day one, though, she would still be pulling Adora into her dorm room. She can't help it. No matter how far they drift apart – emotionally or even geographically – Catra will always come back to her.

She supposes it's time to find out if the same is true for Adora.

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"Where's your dorm?" Catra questions once they are inside, Glimmer standing out on the lawn and likely still gaping at them. Adora scrambles to reach into her jacket pocket and pull out her key.

"This way," she replies as she leads them to the stairs. She feels like she is threatening to burst at the seams, but she doesn't know how to handle the smirk that Catra threw her, much less Catra still referring to her as her girlfriend four years after the messiest breakup in history. Not that Adora has moved on either, but given the concrete wall that Catra built between them, she thought for sure that *she* had. She was expecting to have to hunt Catra down, not to lead her up to her room on the second floor and fumble to unlock the door as she thinks about what to say. Catra stalks inside the moment that Adora pushes the door open, walking straight to the end of the room and eyeing it like she expects Adora's roommate to be hiding under the bed.

"Um, congrats on making the team, by the way. I tried to reach out when I heard, but I didn't think you wanted to talk to me," Adora offers, lamely, as she follows Catra inside and slips her keys back into her pocket. Catra has her back to Adora, but she watches her

tail lash from beneath her long winter coat. She doesnt reply . hstead, the sound of a ipper cuts through the awkward silence. Right. t' s hot inside with coats on. Adora hurries to unip her own jacket just to distract herself from Catra shrugging of f her coat and tossing it over onto the other bed, revealing bare shoulders. Adora almost informs Catra that's actually her roommate's bed, but she loses all the air in her chest when Catra turns around to face her.

She is still wearing heavy ski pants, but all she has on her torso is a tight tank top with a few small rips in it around the hem, no doubt from Catra's claws snagging. Once upon a time, Adora would have gotten distracted by the sight of Catra's nipples hard through her top from the cold, but this is the first time that Adora has seen Catra without a jacket or bandages on since her accident and her eyes are drawn to her scar. t runs from her right armpit up to her neck. f you arent looking for it, the disturbance in her fur pattern from the line of scar tissue isnt too obvious, at least not until you get to her collarbone, where there is knot of scar tissue from her broken collar bone that is large enough to cause a visible bald spot.

Adora is walking forward before she even realizes it, her hand already raised before she catches herself and jerks to a halt just in front of Catra. Her jacket dangles uselessly from her right hand as her left flexes in the air. She swallows, forcing her eyes up to meet Catra's. She expects her to be pissed – the *last* thing that Catra wants to be defined by is her injury – but instead she finds Catra' s gaze burning as it locks with hers. Adora' s jacket slips through her fingers and she doesnt even bother bending to pick it up. That would require breaking eye contact with Catra.

"I know . I saw your tweet," Catra replies. Adora takes a second to process what she is talking about, her own words already having flown from her mind. Thinking isnt made easier by the way Catra' s eyes drop down to her lips. Right. Adora is gaping a little. At least she assumes that is the reason until Catra looks back up, her burning gaze meeting Adora' s, and asks "Are we doing this?" Adora

is baffled. She was just about to ask how Catra saw her tweet when she has her blocked, but she has no idea what *this* is.

"Doing what?" she asks, the words sounding dumb even to her own ears. Not being able to keep up with the places that Catra's mind races to was a factor in their breakup. Adora couldn't anticipate the negative ways that Catra would take her actions and words. She worded things in ways that just reinforced Catra's insecurities and only realized after Catra blew up in response to them. If she wants to have any chance of speaking with Catra again, she needs to keep up now. Unfortunately, that's hard when Catra steps forward and their chests are suddenly brushing together. Catra licks her lips. Her eyes are no less intense than they were when she first turned around.

"*This*. What I thought we'd be doing at the Olympics four years ago. Don't lie that you don't still want me," Catra returns, her voice low and *rough*. Adora's heart climbs into her throat and then *stops*. She is definitely turned on by Catra's presence alone, but she is too *confused* to take Catra up on her offer. Catra hasn't approached her in years, and now she pulls her aside for...what, a *hookup*? Is this just some old fantasy that she wants to fulfil before she goes back to hating Adora? Adora couldn't take that. It would break her heart all over again.

"Of course I still want you – I still fucking *love* you, Catra," Adora replies, her words a little choked as she reaches up and places her hands on Catra's hips. She doesn't want her to pull away or run, not that she thinks her loose touch will really stop her if she decides to bolt. Catra's lips part as she sucks in a shocked breath, but after a moment she releases a quiet growl. Adora's heart falls out of her throat and ends up somewhere around the bottom of her stomach – or maybe her pelvic floor. Catra's growls always did it for her.

"I'm not having that conversation right now, Adora. The Olympics isn't the time to tear into old wounds. We both need our heads on straight for the Games. Do you want to or not?" she asks, her words a bit gruff and loaded with emotion. Adora swallows, staring down at

Catra's hard expression. Her guard is up just like it always is around Adora. Adora's heartrate is racing. She wants to say yes. She wants to press the issue. She wants to ask Catra where she got the audacity from to ignore her for years only to expect her to fall into bed with her again.

Instead, she swallows and manages to ask, "After our last jump?" Her heart pounds in her ears as Catra holds her gaze and then, to Adora's shock, *nods*. The last thing that Adora expected was for Catra to approach her, but it makes a little more sense for her to do it if she just wants to hook up – it's the quintessential Olympic experience, really. Adora didn't think that Catra would agree to *talk*. She might be bullshitting or get cold feet later and vanish before they can have said talk, but Adora is *hopeful*.

Catra reaches up, cutting off Adora's thoughts. She frames her face in her hands and pulls Adora down into a harsh kiss in one smooth movement. Adora's brain *breaks* as Catra licks into her mouth like their last embrace was just yesterday. She knows she just agreed to this, but she wasn't expecting Catra to just go for it like that – she certainly wasn't expecting the easy familiarity of Catra's mouth against hers. Adora's heart beats in her throat as Catra tugs and pulls her down to a better angle.

Adora whimpers a little, finally remembering to move her lips and kiss Catra back. Catra *purrs*, immediately lighting a fire in Adora. She reaches up, finally holding Catra's shoulders like she wanted to earlier. She can feel the knot of the scar beneath her thumb, but it is the furthest thing from her mind as she pulls Catra closer. She wants to feel her every breath, to drink her in while she can. She wouldn't have agreed to this if Catra didn't promise to talk later, but part of her is convinced that talk is never going to happen – or break bad if it does – and that she needs to drink Catra down while she can.

Catra kisses her like it's nothing, like there aren't four years of fighting stretching between them. Adora kind of wants to pull her own hair out and she kind of wants to pin Catra to her mattress. Luckily, Catra makes the call for her, dropping her hands to Adora's

shoulders and swinging them around to guide Adora back towards her bed. Apparently she guessed which was hers correctly upon walking in and just threw her coat on her roommates bed to be an asshole because the backs of Adora's legs collide with the edge of her own mattress quickly as Catra walks them to it.

Catra doesnt hesitate to shove her back on the bed. Adora stares up at her, breathless, as she shifts to scramble to the middle of the narrow twin mattress. Catra smirks down as her, but her eyes are blown out as they roam over Adora and her tail is lashing behind her with excitement. As soon as Adora is fully on the bed, Catra climbs on it with her, swinging her leg over Adora and settling straddled over Adora's hips. Adora feels awestruck staring up at her. She never thought that she would see Catra from this angle again.

"You remember how to do this, Catra?" Catra asks, her tone cocky and smug and everything that Adora has always loved about her. Adora's mouth goes dry as her eyes rake up her body, finally locking gazes with Catra again.

"I want you to sit on my face," she decides. Catra's eyes, impossibly, get rounder.

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Catra is *not* going to sit on Adora's face right before a competition – people have broken their necks that way – but the declaration of intent tells Catra all she needs to know about how much Adora wants this too. She was resistant at first, but promise secured, she pulls at Catra's clothes and her own. The heavy winter clothes get hot quickly, so they end up naked right away. Alright, the heat only justifies going down to their underwear, but Adora seems just as eager to get her hands on Catra as Catra is to do the same with Adora.

Adora left her life, but never her fantasies. Catra has almost broken and propositioned her at competitions before. She knew she wouldnt be able to hold back once they were at the Olympics, but she didnt want to. Almost everybody has sex in the Olympic village. t isnt a big deal. Who is going to notice if she happens to be having it with her ex? W ell, who aside from Glimmer , but Catra doesnt really care about her opinion, especially not when Adora grabs the base of her tail and *tugs*.

Catra mewls, her tail lashing as she instinctively buries her face in the crook of Adora's neck. Adora smells equal parts satisfied and turned on. Catra can just picture the smug smirk on her face as she readjusts her grip and tugs again. This time, Catra clamps down on her shoulder in a harsh bite to stifle the cry that wants to spill out. Adora moans too at that, but apparently not to be outdone, she pulls again. t only makes Catra drive in her teeth further before the voice in her head reminds her *don't hurt her*.

They are going to go into this competition on even ground, even if Adora is pulling the move that she usually reserved especially for when Catra was feeling bratty. Catra releases her shoulder, licking at where her teeth dug in as if she can soothe away any potential bruises with her tongue. Adora gasps. Catra's gaze quickly flicks up. Adora always liked when she got mouthy in any way, but she is still surprised by how flushed Adora's cheeks are already.

"Aw, all worked up? How long *has* it been since someone fucked you like I do?" she purrs to her , because even if she feels like she is ready, she has to dig. Part of it is that she genuinely wants to – maybe even *needs* to – know who else has been in Adora's bed over the last four years, but part of it is just in her nature. Even when they were girlfriends with the rest of their lives together ahead of them, they would poke at each other and be competitive even in bed. Adora's flush is climbing up to her ears now as she blinks at Catra as if to bring her eyes in focus.

"No has fucked me at *all* since the last time you did," Adora returns, stopping Catra dead in her tracks. She blinks down at Adora, feeling

oddly stunned. Her moment of processing gives Adora the time to work through the lust haze. She roams her eyes over Catra's face greedily, searching for any hint to how she feels about that. Catra doesn't know why she is so surprised – Adora has never given even a slight hint on social media of being interested in anyone else, and she *just* said that she was still in love with her – but a part of Catra was convinced that there had to be somebody else, even if it was just a short rebound. Adora's hands tighten on her hips.

"It was always you, Catra," she adds, her voice low. Catra shivers, the fur along her spine fluffing up. She pulls herself together with a growl, swooping down and kissing Adora forcefully, doing everything in her power to claim her mouth. She wants to hear it, but fuck, not *now*. She isn't going to cry her eyes out and show up to the ski slope exhausted. Adora isn't going to distract her and fuck her over. They are going to just *plain* fuck and the rest can wait until after the medals have been handed out.

"Not now," she growls, nipping Adora's lip *hard* to illustrate her point. Adora whines at the bite, nodding and then whining again when that tugs her lip out from between Catra's teeth. Catra is sure that was just the first ploy of many to talk about emotions, but two can play the distraction game. She shifts, sliding her hands up to Adora's chest and kneading at it before she pinches a nipple harshly. Adora always liked it to hurt a little. Adora gasps out, arching up into Catra's hand and proving her right. Catra grins as she ducks down to suck Adora's other nipple into her mouth, laving her rough tongue against it and purring when Adora moans in response.

She has *missed* this. Catra hasn't exactly had the time or motivation to date since she and Adora... Well, they definitely broke up, but in a lot of ways, Catra still felt just as committed to her. Sometimes it felt like she was trapped, unable to sever the red string of fate binding them together. Other times, she wondered what the hell she was doing sleeping alone when Adora could be just a phone call away. She never doubted that Adora would pick up if she reached out. Maybe she wouldn't still want her the same way – and maybe Catra

deserved that as much as Adora deserved her cold shoulder – but they were best friends before they were girlfriends and Adora had made it clear she still wanted to talk.

Catra hasn't missed having someone beneath her the same way that she has missed Adora's love – that's downright insulting to her – but she definitely has still missed it. Adora's moans have always featured in her fantasies and Catra drinks them down, her hands sliding along Adora's body eagerly, unable to settle on one spot because she wants to touch *all* of her. Adora's thighs are strong and muscled beneath her palms, filling her hands just right with their weight. Her chest is plush and addictive to squeeze. The lines of her stomach make Catra want to lick her abs as she traces them with her fingertips.

"Catra," Adora whines, her voice thick with need. All the touching has done a *lot* for her. That probably shouldn't be surprising given how long it has been since someone touched her like this. Catra can smell how turned on she is and it makes her mouth water. She releases Adora's chest with a slick *pop,* looking up to send Adora a smug grin. Adora's face, ears, and chest are flushed. Her lips are parted as she pants and her eyes are dilated when she makes desperate eye contact with Catra. Apparently the grin does enough for her on its own, because she whines again. Or maybe that is because Catra's hands have made their way back to her thighs and are gripping them so she can pull them apart.

After all, there is one part of Adora that Catra wants to touch in *particular*.

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Catra ends up tucked against her left side, nipping along the side of Adora's jaw and whispering dirty things in her ear as she touches her

with one hand. If Adora was any more together , she would note that Catra still remembers *exactly* how to touch her, but as it is, the best she has is noticing that Catra uses her left hand for this now instead of her dominant – and injured – hand. It's hard to register much of anything with Catra's possessive dirty talk in her ear and burning heat spreading through her body from between her legs.

"Listen to yourself. Such pretty whimpers, all for me. I love when you sound *wrecked* like this," Catra purrs. Her voice sounds like it. Adora is *ruined*. Catra is talking to her just like she used to, as if nothing has changed for her – as if she still only ever wants to be with Adora. That does it for Adora as much as Catra's touch, skilled despite how she only had the last few years to perfect using her left hand for this. Adora dutifully whimpers, turning her head and nuzzling against Catra.

"Catra, please," she breathes, begging without shame. Catra purrs, deep and self-satisfied, before fulfilling Adora's mostly-wordless request and kissing her . Catra's tongue is filthy as it licks into her mouth. Now that they have been making out for a while, Adora is aware their first few kisses were sloppier than they seemed after a four-year absence, but it didn't take either of them long to relearn the shape of each other's mouths. Adora is breathless, squirming, and so turned on that she is *desperate* to just come and catch her breath.

She needs the kiss, though. She needs the softness of it. Sure, the movement of Catra's tongue is wicked, but there's as much emotion in the embrace as there is underlying Catra's dirty talk. Adora is overwhelmed, so used to thinking that Catra's affection for her died. She doesn't know how to handle the obvious evidence before her that Catra definitely still *feels*. The depth of it, Adora doesn't know , but she is completely overstimulated and she loves it. She loves Catra. She is so used to that thought being tinged with sadness, but now Catra breaks the kiss and nips at the corner of Adora's jaw and all Adora can think is *yes*.

"Shh. You're thinking too much. Just focus on this," Catra breathes in her ear. Those words only make Adora's mind race more – *Catra is*

still attuned enough to her to tell – but Catra lightly tugging on her earlobe with her teeth finally blanks out Adora's mind. She closes her eyes, moaning and arching her hips as she tries to just focus on how fucking good it feels to have Catra surrounding her all over again. After all, the sooner she comes, the sooner she gets to touch Catra back.

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Adora gets really cuddly after she comes, wrapping around Catra and nuzzling into her . Once she has gotten comfortable, she closes her eyes and just breathes heavily for several long minutes. When Catra pictured this, it was a lot more antagonistic, pinning Adora against the closest surface and having her way with her, but things changed when Catra asked Adora for her consent. In her head that was a quick yes or no and that was it, they were having angry sex against the wall, but it turns out that Catra was right: it's far too easy to let Adora in again.

Catra shouldn't be *snuggling* with her like this, it is completely at odds with her plan to just get physical and only think about emotions after the medals have been distributed. She stills wraps around Adora in return and holds her close. She justifies it to herself – surely people who are just hooking up cuddle afterwards too – but she knows that really, she just wants to hold Adora and she likes being held herself. Adora rubs her face into Catra's neck and Catra just tilts her head back and gives her better access, purring softly.

Eventually, Adora seems to "wake up" enough to start running her hands along Catra's body again. She is still nuzzled beneath her chin, limp and perfectly happy to cuddle even as her hands find Catra's thighs and she pulls her forward. Adora shifts her own leg forward to meet her, giving Catra her thigh to rub against. Catra happily takes it, setting to scent marking the top of Adora's head as

she grinds down on her leg. Adora's lips find their way to the uninjured side of her neck, spreading open-mouthed kisses down the line of her throat.

Catra sighs happily, more than happy to grind herself off on the strong muscle of Adora's thigh. It's so nice to have it be something other than her own hand or a toy to get off with. She rubs her cheek down from the top of Adora's face to nuzzle along her cheek, quickly finding herself captured in a filthy kiss. Adora takes control this time, flexing her thigh as she licks into Catra's mouth. Catra can't stop the purr buzzing in her chest as she rocks down into the blissful sensation spiking from the contact. Sure, it's slower and more affectionate than what she had pictured, but fuck, it's *good*.

"Can I eat you out?" Adora asks, breathless, when Catra pulls away to rub her cheek along Adora's jaw. Catra's tail lashes against the mattress. Adora's thigh is good, but that would definitely be *better*. Catra isn't about to risk Adora's neck, but they'll be fine as long as Adora is in control. Catra releases Adora and rolls over onto her back. She's at the very edge of the mattress, but the wall is at her back, so she isn't at risk of falling out. She leers at Adora as she props one leg up, giving her a *view*.

"If you still remember how," she scoffs. Adora's expression screws up with indignation. She's fucking adorable, determination setting her jaw as she reaches for Catra's hips and tugs her closer to the middle of the bed.

"I'm going to make you *scream*," she tells her, almost like a threat, as she shifts to kneel between Catra's legs. Catra grins up at the ceiling as she lays back. She is more than happy to let Adora *try*.

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Catra doesnt scream. t’ s been a long time since Adora did this and it takes her a bit to get in her groove again. Once she does though, she swears she enters a kind of zen headspace. t isnt dissimilar to the satisfaction of the post-orgasm afterglow, contentment and fire buzing through her body as she loses herself in Catra. She always loved the taste of her. Between Catra’s thighs might as well be Adora’s happy place. She loves when her strong thighs twitch around the sides of her head, not to mention the little growls, purrs, and gasps that she draws out of her until Catra eventually comes moaning.

t isnt the scream that Adora promised, but maybe that is for the best. Bed rocking might be normal in the Olympic village, but they dont need to get security called on them. Besides, easing Catra over might be as good as a shattering orgasm. Catra yanks on her ponytail, arches up into her mouth, and comes with a growling moan that has Adora instantly turned on again. t might just be the sexiest sound she has ever heard. She licks along Catra, cleaning her up as best she can, as Catra collapses back against the mattress panting and purring.

Adora shifts up as soon as she is done, eager to take advantage of Catra’s pliant and content state post-orgasm to get in some more cuddles with her. When she pulls Catra against her chest, Catra rolls over without resistance, nuzing beneath her chin and burying her nose against Adora’s pulse point just like she used to when she wanted comfort. Adora shoves down the coo that wants to rise in her throat and instead dedicates herself to squeezing Catra tightly against her chest, scattering kisses over her ears. Theyre so soft. Fuck, she has missed this so much.

Catra’s purr is strong, rolling through Adora’s chest as she hugs her close. Adora wonders if she should try to go for round two. Catra will stay longer then, at least, and Adora is certainly turned on enough for it. She doesnt want this to be over . She doesnt know if Catra will go right back to ignoring her once they finish. At best she will probably start ignoring her once they get their first practice run on

the slopes. Maybe she will be willing to at least do *this* until their event actually rolls around and they do their qualifying jumps.

Adora cant decide if she' s grateful or annoyed that they wont be competing until the second week of the games. She doesnt know if Catra is going to give her the cold shoulders until theyre done, but she also doesnt know if Catra will even be sticking around the village after she finishes competing. Catra shifts in her arms and Adora tightens her grip, her heartrate spiking at the idea of Catra pulling away. Catra snorts, yawning widely against Adora's neck before she rubs her cheek there.

"Y our roommate's going to show up eventually. Ive got to go sleep off the jetlag before my appointment in the morning, anyway ," Catra reminds her even as she marks Adora. Adora wants to ask *what appointment*, but she can guess that it's with a trainer or one of the many health and beauty services on offer around the Olympic village. They have to stay in top shape and are about to be watched by the world, after all.

"Sleep it of f here," she says, burying her face against one of Catra' s soft ears. She half expects Catra to laugh at her and half expects her to just pull away , but Catra is silent for several long moments.

"No. No emotions, not until the medals have fallen," Catra says, her voice quiet but leaving no room for argument. Adora swallows. Is it foolish to feel hopeful at that statement? She wants Catra to stay , yes, but she wants to reconcile *more* and Catra really seems to be implying that she wants that too. As much as Adora wants to ask what changed, she cant jeopardize this. She blows out a breath and nods, releasing Catra reluctantly.

Catra climbs over her, not looking at Adora as she gathers her clothes from around the bed – and the room. She doesnt seem mad, which is a first in four years, but Adora chews on her lip, her anxiety building as Catra prepares to leave. As Catra shrugs on her jacket, she finally looks up to Adora again. She hesitates in the middle of reaching for her zipper with her right hand, dropping it to her side

before seeming to realize that she froze and reaching up again with her left hand this time. She turns towards the door as she zips her jacket up.

"Same time tomorrow , my room? I'm in 312 in building C. I brought some toys with me," Catra proposes, causing Adora's jaw to drop. Catra glances back over her shoulder, smirking when she catches sight of Adora's expression. "Come on, Miss America, we both have two Olympics worth of sex to catch up on. Call it stamina training," Catra teases her. Adora flushes. So what if her nod is ridiculously eager? She can't turn down an offer like that. Besides, Catra's melodic laugh as she walks out is its own reward.

Chapter End Notes

I already said I know nothing about sports, but I did Math on the statistics of skiers and Olympic slots between countries (as well as the list of most competitive countries in the Winter Olympics) to determine that the USA would be way more competitive to get to represent than Canada, plus I often set my modern AUs in the US, so Catra and Adora grew up there and Adora represented them at her first Olympics before Angella poached her for Canada and the commonwealth. Catra calls her Miss America as a dig at the team she "abandoned".
These are not meant to be the Olympics from this year (I've actually had this idea since December 2020, but I figured now was the time to finally do it lol), but I did reference things like the schedule from this year to get an idea for how these things can conceivably go, whether or not they're standard. Obviously none of the COVID rules are in place, so Catra and Adora can hang out as much as they want in the village.

The Torch Reignites

Chapter Notes

> Assume that any time that Catra and Adora arent together , Adora is either a) taking care of her body (eating, sleeping, training, etc) or b) getting lectured by her friends who think she has gone insane for agreeing to this.
> Im a practical joke played on myself and it' s four chapters now.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra isnt supposed to see Adora again until tonight. She already worked out a schedule with her roommate. Mermista is already married, so she doesnt seem to have any interest in hooking up specially with her husband during the games, but she was surprisingly chill about Catra asking to have the room at certain times. They looked at when their training times were and settled on her clearing out for an hour or two every other night. Catra has this all planned out.

If only she had accounted for *Adora*. Catra is in line at the free burger joint in the village for an early lunch when she hears the shrill tones of Adora's new best friend and turns to find Adora walking in flanked by the skating duo of the year or whatever the fuck. Their eyes meet and Adora's light up in an instant. Catra quickly turns back around, twitching her ears back as a whispered discussion breaks out near the door, but a minute later Adora is sidling up beside her.

"Im not letting you cut in line," Catra tells her , not looking away from the back of the Armenian athlete right in front of her.

"I'll wait to order until Glimmer and Bow get to the front. Have lunch with us? Please?" Adora asks, knocking their shoulders together . The movement is so familiar , Catra almost starts to lean into it out of

habit. That alone is proof enough that she needs to not take Adora up on her offer, though.

"I'm not hanging around, it would ruin my schedule. I'm going straight to the gym after this," Catra rebukes, still not looking at Adora. Even with just her periphery, she makes out Adora pouting at her, though she doesn't seem sad, just disappointed. Catra would be shocked in Adora actually expected that to work. Catra has a plan and she's sticking to it.

"I'll see you tonight?" Adora asks, as if expecting Catra to have changed her mind. As if. Catra grunts an affirmative, shuffling forward when the line moves up. Adora hovers for a moment and then lets her go, turning away to join her friends at the back of the line.

Catra should have known better than to tell Adora where she was going.

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"You're insufferable," is Catra's greeting to her. She doesn't look away from her form in the mirror as she does her torso twists. Adora happily drops down onto the yoga mat she just laid by Catra's side. She had to eat her own lunch and then dodge Glimmer and Bow's concern, but she found Catra pretty quickly once she made her way to the massive gym facilities that take up a corner of the Olympic village.

"If you didn't want me to come, you shouldn't have told me where you were going," she chirps, setting to a set of simple stretches. Catra's ear flicks and her eyes narrow as she watches herself in the mirror.

"Thanks, I won't make that mistake again," she drawls between steady, controlled breaths. Adora pouts, doing her best to send Catra puppy eyes, but it's hard when Catra isn't looking at her. Catra must notice it in her periphery, though, because her ear flicks and her expression softens just a little from the hard glare that she was giving the mirror moments ago.

"I need to focus," she says, almost like she is arguing with Adora. She is definitely trying to get her to go away, but also, she isn't leaving or insulting her. That is honestly progress for them. Adora frowns, trying to think of what she can say as she stretches out her arms.

"We always used to push each other to be better when we trained together," she tries. Appealing to Catra's competitive side is either going to work or make her mad. Adora never realized how much *baggage* the competition between them had given Catra until their screaming match after her injury. It was clear that Catra had some big issues with feeling belittled. If neither of them cared about their sport, Adora is certain that they would have spent the last four years together, but that competition drove a wedge between them.

Catra pauses in the middle of a twist, blowing out a slow breath and then dropping the weighted ball she is using as a weight to the ground beside her. It falls only a few inches with a dull thud. Finally, Catra turns to face her with narrowed eyes. Adora sucks in a breath and does her best to send Catra what she hopes is a non-threatening and pleading look.

"Maybe I just miss you like crazy and always wanted to be at the Olympics with you. But you said no emotions," she rushes out. Catra's ears pin back at the words and she quickly looks away, her tail twitching by her side. At least she doesn't look mad. Adora sits and waits for judgement. After several long seconds, Catra blows out a breath and reaches up to push her bangs out of her face. The doctors cut her hair short when it became matted with blood during the accident – plus it was easier to care for as she healed – but she has kept it that way ever since.

"And you're doing a terrible job of sticking to it. But fine, you can hang around, but I'm not competing with you before we take our qualifying jumps, Adora. I'm not going to risk straining something before the events," Catra tells her , sending Adora a firm look. Adora's heart leaps in her chest and she quickly nods. Catra didn't used to be this cautious around competitions, but Adora gets why she isn't taking any risks now .

"I can do that," Adora agrees quickly . Catra snorts and sends her a look that makes it clear she isn't as confident in that as Adora is, but Adora grins back. If Catra will hang out with her , she can definitely shut up about how she has dreamed about this and just enjoy getting to *have* it.

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Adora does manage to just be her regular chatty self and not ask Catra *too* much as they work out alongside each other. They never do the same exercise at the same time and Catra purposefully doesn't pay attention to Adora' s reps. She feels like Adora is counting hers, but she could just be paranoid. She sends Adora a flat look whenever she asks her something about her life, but Adora sends her an innocent look back every time.

Some of them Catra doesn't see the harm in answering – mostly the ones about anything related to the sport – but whenever Adora prods at her carefully guarded personal life, Catra ignores her. She is only active on social media to garner attention and sponsors, and she tries to keep her real life out of public view. If reporters and hungry fans haven't pestered information out of her , Adora isn't going to manage it in the middle of a crowded gym.

"Have you ever taken a trip to Canada just to ski and not compete?" Adora asks, the fiftieth question she has asked since they settled

into a rhythm. Catra snorts.

"Are you really trying to recruit me in the middle of the gym?" she asks. Adora's expression is indignant, her mouth falling open as she fumbles for words for a moment.

"No! I just wanted to know if you'd- *Catra*, come on, you know what I wanted," Adora whines. Catra huffs, looking away. Of course she does. Adora wants to follow her to whatever resort she visits just like she did to the gym. Adora lowers down her weights, standing from the bench and circling around to stand in front of Catra so Catra has to look at her. Catra resolutely glares down at her feet and pins her ears back.

"I like skiing in Canada way better, alright? The views are fantastic, it's less crowded, there are fewer entitled assholes at the resorts, it's just *better*. I think you would like it too. I'd like to ski with you again without a competition hanging over our heads. That's all," Adora says. Her voice is low, but Catra is distinctly aware of how many people are in this gym. This is the farthest thing from a private conversation there is. Well, she supposes they could be talking in front of reporters, but they aren't allowed in the Olympic village.

Catra turns away from Adora, abandoning her reps in the middle. She follows all of Adora's social media accounts with the same shell accounts that she uses to keep an eye on the skiing scene in general. She knows that Adora travels to the US regularly, both for competitions and to train at different resorts. Being one of the top athletes in her field brings her sponsorships and she can afford the travel. She could come meet Catra for a weekend in America.

Catra might be skilled, but she has only just managed to build herself back up to Adora's level after the accident. She managed to get enough sponsorships to pay her way to the games, but she has had to work day jobs to afford her training and her physical therapy. Getting into the Games might be the turn around that she needs in that regard, but few people become athletes in winter sports with the

intent of getting rich. Some people manage it, sure, but many of the athletes at the Games are living at the poverty level.

Adora is one of those few golden examples of an athlete that has a nice lifestyle secured and can fly to train wherever she likes. You pretty much only see them in things like snowboarding and skiing, but the trust fund her parents set up for her before they died and her inheritance helps too. If anyone should be flying to visit someone, it should be her. The only reason for Catra to fly up to see *Adora* is if she wants to woo her to the ways of Canadian skiing.

"I'll see you tonight," Catra says, still not looking at Adora. It's an obvious dismissal, but she draws in a breath and waits to see Adora will take it or if she is going to make a scene in the middle of the gym. For several long seconds, Adora stands at her back. Catra's heartrate steadily climbs as she waits. She half expects to have pushed Adora to her limit and get a declaration of *Im done being jerked around by you*, or something. Catra has heard Adora's voice filled with vitriol now after she pushed Adora to her limit in their big fight.

She expects to hear it again, but after what must be ten, maybe fifteen *endless* seconds, Adora lets out a harsh sigh and walks away. Catra doesnt breathe easier with Adora's footsteps retreating. She reaches up, pushing her hair out of her face as she hangs her head. She tries to take steadying breaths and barely manages not to hyperventilate. She doesnt know why she thought she could just cut off any emotions until the medals were given out. It's fucking *Adora*. Both of them are going to keep pushing until one of them snaps and lashes out.

Catra cant take another injury right before her Olympic debut.

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Adora doesnt really know what to expect when she shows up at Catra's door that night. She half expects Catra not to be there after the gym, but she answers when Adora knocks. Adora almost let Glimmer convince her that she shouldnt go, but despite Adora's building confusion and frustration, she cant walk away from Catra. There will be no hope for them rebuilding their bridge if Adora doesnt show. She knows that she fucked up when they parted, but Catra also twisted her intentions. Adora never meant to belittle or hurt her. She never *wanted* to. They both were at fault, and they both said shitty things in the blow up.

Adora just wants to fucking *talk* about it. She wants to know that this truce they have isnt just going to last the two weeks of the games. She knew she was pushing in the gym, but she was being genuine, which she doesnt think is something that Catra can say. She's running some kind of game here and Adora is along for the ride whether she likes it or not.

When Catra opens the door, she has a carefully blank expression, but her ears twitch back when she sees Adora's face. Silently, she steps aside and lets Adora in. Catra closes the door behind her and gestures vaguely to the only made bed in the small dorm room. There is a small suitcase open on the floor at its foot and Adora can see two satin bags inside that she can guess the contents of, but Catra's expression is...strange.

"Sit," Catra orders with none of the seductive purr she used yesterday. Adora draws in a breath and follows orders. Okay, so they are having a talk. Catra begins pacing, not looking at her. Yeah, *emotions* are definitely happening. Adora takes a moment to appreciate the sight of Catra in body-molding leggings and a cropped sweater. She isnt wearing a bra, and Adora knows that not just because Catra doesnt like them, but because the sweater is cropped high enough for Adora to see the bottom of her tits.

Catra was definitely still planning to go through with sex when she got dressed, but her pacing says otherwise now. After a moment, Catra draws to a halt in front of Adora, glaring indistinctly at her

shoulder. Adora is still wearing her jacket, though it is unzipped to show off the tight t-shirt she is wearing underneath. Catra isn't even paying attention to the fact that Adora isn't wearing a bra either, though. Her tail twitches tensely behind her.

"No emotions, right? But-" she cuts off with a frustrated growl, turning away to glare at her roommate's bed instead. Adora fists her hands in the comforter. That *but* was either Catra chiding her for not following the rule or preparing to introduce emotions for herself. Adora's blood thrums with anxiety. The fact that Catra won't look at her makes her wonder – hope – if it was the latter. Catra takes a deep breath, her shoulders rising and falling.

"I've been working my ass for four years. All I wanted was to get back here. I couldn't think about fixing us until I made it," Catra's voice trails down to a whisper. Adora can barely hear it over the blood rushing her ears. "Adora, I *want* to, but I need to do this first. So just stop trying to get in my life again," Catra's voice grows stronger, taking on a wry twist, "Stick to getting in my pants. I want us to go our hardest on the slopes and I want us both to podium when this is done. We could do it. You know we could. So let's keep our heads on the Games and worry about us after, okay?" Catra finishes, her tone slightly pleading.

Adora swallows, still fisting the covers in her hands. Okay, so maybe Catra has thinking about reconnecting for longer than Adora thought. Maybe the next Olympics were always going to be the goalpost they needed to reach before their relationship could be repaired. This isn't just some Olympic village hookup, at least. Adora forces herself to let go of the bed, standing and cautiously stepping forward. Catra's ears, swiveled back to listen for her response, quickly pin to the sides of her head. She stiffens when Adora wraps around her back, pulling her close in a hug.

"Okay. I get waiting to talk about it so that we're focused for our runs, or whatever, but I've always wanted to tear up the Olympic village with you. Can we? I promise not to pry or, whatever, I just want to do all the stuff that we planned leading up to the last games. It's a

miracle that we're back here and get a chance to do it again," Adora asks. Maybe she is pushing too far, but she thinks Catra might give this to her, and she has a *point*.

If Catra doesn't allow it, then they'll never get to do this again. The chances that the two of them make it to the next games are small. Catra shifts in her arms, and for a moment Adora thinks that she is going to pull away, but instead she reaches up and hooks her hands over Adora's arms wrapped around her, as if to hold her there. Adora wasn't going to pull away, but the action makes her heart jump in her chest. She squeezes Catra tightly against her.

"Okay, I guess. I'm not hanging out with fucking Sparkles, though. I can't stand her," Catra returns, her voice gruff. Adora would point out that Catra has never even properly *met* her, but instead she squeals and hooks her chin over Catra's shoulder so she can kiss her cheek. She can work on warming Catra up to Glimmer later, preferably after Catra has unblocked her on social media. She is too excited about the prospect of getting a redo on four years ago to worry about Catra's dislike of her new friends.

"Deal," Adora agrees. Catra's tail sways with amusement behind her, hitting against Adora's legs. After a moment, Catra twists around, finally facing Adora again. There is no trace of the earlier tension on her face now, a mischievous look sparkling in her eyes and a sly smile tugging at the corner of her lips. Adora doesn't doubt that it is a bit of false bravado, but that look on Catra's face turns her on regardless, and now that Adora is *certain* they are going to talk when this is all done, she doesn't mind returning to the original purpose for their meeting.

"Want to see what I brought?" Catra asks, her voice teasing and smug. She knows that Adora does. Adora doesn't even bother to hide the way she lights up at the words. Catra laughs as she pulls away.

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There's an instant change in Adora when Catra brings out the strap-on she brought – in two sizes, because she always liked it smaller than Adora and she doesn't know how much Adora can take now. Adora immediately reaches for it and Catra jerks it back out of her reach, smirking when Adora has to blink the lust haze from her eyes to send Catra a confused and pleading pout.

"Princess, this is for *you*. Maybe I'll let you use it on me later if I like the way you moan for me," Catra tells her, watching the way Adora's eyes dilate in response. It's the exact response that she wanted. Adora drops her hands, eagerly watching Catra lower the toy back down. At a moment, she pulls her eyes away from the toy to run them hungrily along Catra's body instead. Catra is more than happy to cock one hip out and place her hand on it. She dressed to give Adora plenty to look at. Normally she doesn't wear this sweater without something underneath since it's impossible to move in without having a nip slip, but that wasn't going to be a downside tonight. Finally, Adora tears her eyes away from following the lines of Catra's body and meets her gaze.

"And how long has it been since somebody fucked you until the bedframe was slamming against the wall? I know you must miss it," Adora asks, fucking *cocky* and smirking at Catra when her jaw drops in response. Her tail lashes behind her, heat rising in her gut that she *tries* to quiet, but fuck, Adora is right. She isn't always in the mood to be railed like that, but when it's what she wants it's the best thing ever. She closes her mouth, narrow her eyes in on Adora.

"I'm going to bend you over the bed," she declares. Adora flushes, blinking at Catra with wide-eyed excitement. Catra smirks at her, walking forward to crowd against her and herd her toward the bed. Adora lets her, her tongue peeking out to wet her lips as Catra drops the strap onto the end of the bed and then grabs Adora by her hips so she can force her back against the edge of the mattress. "This is

what she was planning from the start, but now she is riled up and she *needs* to have Adora bent over for her.

She kisses Adora as she runs her hands up her body, pushing Adora's jacket off her shoulders and tossing it to the floor. Adora kisses her back eagerly, just as worked up as Catra is by the traded teasing. Catra runs her hands over Adora's tight top. It practically conforms to her muscles. It somehow feels dirtier to touch her in it than if she was totally topless. Catra was a little preoccupied when Adora walked in, but now she can appreciate the fact that Adora isn't even wearing a bra. She slips a hand between them, squeezing at Adora's chest and rubbing her thumb against her hard nipple through her shirt.

Adora responds by nipping at her bottom lip, tugging it gently the way that Catra likes. She lets out a purring growl, her tail lashing behind her as she quickly drops her hands to the hem of Adora's shirt. She has changed her mind: she needs her naked *yesterday*. She breaks the kiss just long enough to pull the shirt up over Adora's head and then presses forward, growling a little just from excitement as she kisses her again. She loves the slide of Adora's lips against hers. She catches herself purring as Adora runs her hands along her sides, taking advantage of her exposed skin.

Catra planned her outfit specifically to break Adora's brain. Given the talk at the beginning, those plans got a little derailed, but Adora seems to be appreciating it now, running her hands along every inch of Catra that she can reach. She even slips her hand up beneath the edge of the crop top to squeeze at her chest and bury her hand in the soft fluff right over Catra's heart. It's especially thick with the cold of winter right now and Adora seems to enjoy touching it just as much as her chest, though eventually her hands slide down to grope her ass instead.

Catra grins into the kiss as Adora suddenly pauses before sliding her hands all around her hips. Catra happily lets Adora feel her up. No matter how much she touches, she isn't going to find underwear. Catra doesn't typically wear it with tight clothing anymore. She just

doesn't see the point. Besides, today in particular it would get in the way of the brief harness for the strap. Adora lets out a soft groan as she gives up her search and grips Catra's hips tightly. Catra gets the distinct impression she is holding herself back. Catra smirks as she leans back so she can drop her hands to Adora's waistband.

"We t enough for some fun?" she teases. Adora's eyes are hooded and dark as she lets out a small moan in response, her nostrils flaring.

"You're only making me want you more, you know," Adora returns, which isn't exactly a yes, except for how it totally is. Catra continues to undo her fly as she lets a hint of fangs peek through on the edge of her smile.

"God. I want you thinking about all the things that you wish I'd let you do while I take you over the edge of the bed. Maybe I'll even let you do some of them when I'm finished," Catra returns. In response, Adora reaches down and eagerly shoves down her own pants herself.

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Catra looks ridiculously hot in just her cropped hoodie that hides *nothing* and the brief harness for the strap. Adora kind of wants to ask her to switch out the toy for the larger one that she showed Adora, but it has been awhile since she did this with someone else. She might be able to take more when she is totally in control, but that isn't now. Besides, her mind kind of blanks out where Catra is standing there in an "outfit" that is somehow hotter than being just plain naked. She forgets about her internal debate and Catra bending her over the bed certainly doesn't *help* her remember anything.

Catra keeps teasing her with the tip of the toy, using a hand on the base of it to rub it against her going from her clit to her entrance. She teases her entrance with it just long enough for Adora to think that *this* time she will finally let her have it and then she rubs it back down and rocks it between her legs instead where it isn't nearly enough stimulation. Adora whines, burying her face in the pillow that Catra moved for her. She is trying to hold out, but she knows what it is going to take for Catra to actually give her what she wants.

And fuck, she needs it. She rubs her face down into the pillow, as if getting oxygen deprived will convince Catra that she needs it without having to beg. She doesn't really know why she is holding out except to be competitive. Catra says that she's a brat – sometimes, other times she says that she's a *good little girl* – and Adora guesses that's why she tries to stifle the needy noise rising in her throat. It's been awhile and she feels like she has something to prove, but any attempts to be quiet go out the window when Catra reaches up and grabs her ponytail, pulling her head back so she can't hide in the pillow anymore.

The yank on her hair hurts and this isn't a comfortable position to have her head pulled back in, but it sends a jolt through her and she moans, restlessly shifting her hips. Catra *purrs* behind her, apparently satisfied with the strangled noise that she has drawn out of Adora – although not pleased *enough* because the toy is still rubbing against her in a terrible tease that Catra seems no closer to ending. It's getting harder and harder to remember why she is holding out the more desperate that she grows.

"Aww, c'mon Adora. I want to hear your pretty voice," Catra purrs behind her, her tone smug and almost *demeaning*, which only makes Adora wetter. She tries, valiantly, to hold out.

She lasts fifteen seconds.

"Please, Catra, I *need* it," she begs, her voice already wrecked, but she thinks she would be significantly less desperate if Catra had just started fucking her right away. This build up is ruining her. Catra

shifts the toy up, rubbing it against her entrance again, but she doesn't push in. Adora, a bit petulantly, thumps her fist against the mattress in frustration and tries to force her hips back onto the toy. It slips to the side before Catra takes a quick step back, leaving her with no stimulation at all – except for her hair, where Catra is pulling her ponytail even harder.

"Being a brat isn't going to get you what you want. Ask nicely," Catra replies, her tone *cocky.* Adora groans, yanking her head forward. Catra lets go of her ponytail at the first sign of real resistance. Adora buries her face down into the pillow as Catra drops her now-free hand to her lower back, holding Adora in place. Adora wants to shoot back that she *did* ask, she fucking begged, but she knows that Catra wants more. After a second of gathering herself, Adora decides that she's too desperate to wait longer. She turns her head, resting her cheek against the pillow and drawing in a steady breath.

"Fuck me. Make me yours again. *Fill me*," Catra," she asks, her voice rough. She sounds desperate even to her own ears, but she doesn't care, because the toy finally presses against her entrance and then *in*. A measure of peace immediately sweeps through Adora. She sighs softly, shifting her hips a little to a better angle as Catra rocks her hips slowly. In a few moments the slow pace will be torturous, but for now it's a relief. She can hear Catra's tail lashing when it hits the mattress or swishes over the back of the harness. It feels good to know that Catra is affected by this too.

"There you go. Feels good?" Catra questions. Her voice is still seductive and purring, but there is a genuine question in there. Adora smiles to herself as she nods against the pillow. It may have been awhile and Catra clearly wants to be careful, but Adora doesn't need it.

"I have toys nearly twice this size. It's good," Adora assures. Catra draws in a sharp breath. Adora turns her head a little more. It is uncomfortable to look over her shoulder, but it is worth it for the sight of Catra buried in her with blown out eyes and her tail twitching. Adora smirks to herself as she drops her head back against the

pillow. “Well? Think you can make me forget my name with that little thing?” she teases, cocky herself now . Catra’s tail lashes harshly to the side and a competitive growl rises in her throat as she grabs Adora’s hips with both of her hands.

“Warn me before I blow your back out,” she growls, and then she *rocks* forward. Adora’s mind blanks out as the bed slams against the wall.

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Catra doesn't know how you go about filing a noise complaint in the Olympic village, but she has a feeling her neighbors might figure it out. She loses herself, determined to do everything that Adora asked her to. She wants Adora to not be able to walk out when she is done, utterly wrecked and wondering how she ever made it even a day without Catra. She rises to all the taunts and it only makes it more satisfying when Adora is reduced to writhing and crying out. She is actually *crying*, salt on the air, but she nods desperately when Catra purrs in her ear asking her if she loves it, so it isn't bad. It just goes to show how intense it gets for her.

Catra is pretty sure that the paint on the wall would be chipped if she pulled the bed away from it, but the real proof for how they utterly lose themselves comes when she flips Adora over so she can show her clit proper attention and finally bring her over. On her hips are crescent marks – eight in total, but only four that have broken skin – from where Catra’s claws inadvertently dug in as she held Adora steady. She knows that Adora likes her claws, but she didn't usually leave anything more than temporary marks with them that faded within minutes.

Adora whines and rolls her hips impatiently, not seeming to give a single shit about the marks on her own body. She certainly didn't say

anything when Catra first made them, nor did she make any sound that seemed particularly pained at any point, but Catra doesnt like the idea of marking her accidentally even if Adora liked it. She drops her hands to fist the comforter on either side of Adora as she sets to rocking her hips again. Adora immediately throws her head back, letting out a loud *ah!* that sounds as excited as it does relieved.

Catra waits until she is sure that she is in utter control of herself before she slows the rocking of her hips and sets to touching Adora's clit with her left hand instead, bringing her over quickly after all the buildup with harsh movements. Adora – unlike Catra yesterday – nearly screams when she comes, throwing her arm over her mouth and biting down on it harshly to stifle the sound. Catra drinks in the sight of Adora splayed out for her, drenched in sweat, and hair a mess with tear trails running down her face.

Her chest heaves as she pants for air , but her eyes are closed and her face is peaceful. She has that utter contentment of someone who has been fucked through a mattress. Catra eases the toy out from where she was holding it in her, stepping back to give Adora room to move. She reaches down, carefully petting down along Adora's sides as she continues to pant and lie limp on the bed.

"C'mon, Adora. Let' s get you up on the bed and then you can nap," Catra encourages her, sliding her hands down to the back of her thighs so she can tug her up and help. Adora gives a small whine of protest, but she reluctantly flutters her eyes open. They arent *focused*, but she follows Catra's directions and lets her swing her fully onto the bed. She is facing the wrong way, but the pillow was already down near the foot anyway. Catra gets it readjusted beneath her head and then tries to step away, but Adora whines loudly and stops her in her tracks.

"Come cuddle,"she mumbles. Her eyes are barely open and she sounds like she just might fall asleep. Catra doesnt know how much longer Mermista is going to be hanging out at her husband's room, but she is sure that they have time for Adora to lie down and just soak in the afterglow. She has something to do first though.

I'll be right there. I'm just putting this away ," she assures, gesturing down to the harness still settled on her hips. Adora releases a noise of displeasure, but her eyes fall closed. Catra doesn't have to go far , walking to the small bathroom just within the dorm' s door and slipping off the harness. It needs to be washed now – not just the toy, but the harness itself got ruined from how wet Catra was – but that can wait until later. Catra sets it on the counter and then opens up the cabinet, pulling out the small first aid kit that every room comes with.

She took stock of its contents when she first moved in. She quickly gathers antiseptic wipe packets, returning to find Adora frowning at the empty dorm room. Catra ignores the warmth spreading through her chest at seeing Adora's obvious disquiet from her absence, climbing into the bed beside her. Adora's eyes flutter open and she smiles up at Catra, but she pauses when she sees what she has in her hands. Catra manages not to cringe as she lays out beside her, but Adora quickly wraps her arms around her .

"I need to take care of your hips, Adora," Catra protests, though she drapes an arm over Adora's back and squeezes her close. It is supposed to be a parting hug, but Adora buries her face against the side of Catra's head and does her best to get a face full – though not a mouthful – of her hair.

"It doesn't hurt. Y ou know I like it. I want cuddles," Adora protests. She's adorable, but Catra huffs and shifts her arm so she can place a hand on Adora's shoulder and gently push her back again. Adora pouts as she reluctantly lets Catra push her into lying down again.

"I don't want either of us to even have bruises by the time we get on the slopes, alright? Just let me take care of you," Catra tells her , shifting back to kneel beside her. Adora's pout clears and she gazes up at Catra with a lot more reverence than ripping open an antiseptic wipe package deserves. Catra looks away, feeling her cheeks heat as she sets to gently cleaning Adora's hips. They are already scabbed over, but she wants to do what she can. She keeps her

claws clean, but she never meant to make the marks in the first place.

"I'm sorry. I know it didn't take you out of it, but it won't happen again," Catra tells her, bending to kiss one of the fading marks that didn't break skin before she makes one final pass. When she glances up, she finds Adora watching her with hooded eyes. She seems a little more awake now. She frowns a little as Catra stands and throws away the remnants of the wipes and packaging.

"I really don't care, Catra. I know it was an accident. They happen," Adora replies. Catra sighs as she climbs back in the bed. Adora quickly pulls Catra into her arms, cuddling her tightly. Catra wrinkles her noise at the smell of the antiseptic, but she wants to cuddle too if she's honest, so she lets Adora rearrange them until Catra is draped over her top half, her hips twisted off to the side to avoid pressuring Adora's. That second part is stubbornness on her part.

"I've got issues with injuries now, Adora. I want us both at our best when we go out there," Catra tells her, her voice low. Adora pauses. After a moment, she reaches up and threads her fingers through Catra's hair, cradling her head close.

"That's earned. It'll be healed by next week, though. I'll be okay," Adora assures, dropping a kiss against her ear. Catra lets out a slow breath. She needed to hear *that*, not Adora hurrying to tell her it's fine. She knows that Adora is okay with it, but *Catra* isn't. She lets out a small grumble, burying her face against Adora's neck and breathing in. Adora's scent always calmed her before and it still does now. It takes her several seconds of breathing in and willing her heart to slow down before a gentle rumble begins to roll through her.

"Yesss," Adora hisses, seemingly to herself. Catra snorts, but she keeps purring for Adora as she cuddles her tightly against her chest. If Catra didn't know better, she would accuse Adora of missing their purring cuddles more than the sex, but they both know that is a *fact* and Adora wouldn't be in the slightest bit ashamed of it. Now they seem to have really established their rules, Catra doesn't mind

cuddling Adora through the afterglow. They'll have to get dressed soon if only to avoid Mermista walking in on them, but for now, Catra sinks down into Adora's arms.

If she's honest, she missed this too.

Chapter End Notes

Catra, Adora: Freeski slopestyle.
Scorpia, Mermista: Snowboarding.
Entrapta, Perfuma: Biathlon.
Glimmer, Bow: Pairs ice dancing.
Sea Hawk: Skeleton.
Frosta: daughter of the prime minister, there for a bunch of ceremonial bullshit.

The Games (Past & Present)

Chapter Notes

> Catra's injury is inspired by the corruption of her right side that took place in the portal (and maybe I'm working something out about my own disability, shush), but it feels remiss to not mention RWBY, since her injury is reminiscent of the one she receives in that, though the only real similarity is the fact that Catra injures her dominant hand and it fucks with her career. Maybe I wanna plug a fic I love shh (major TWs for that fic tho, heads up).

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Making her way back to the Olympics was all that Catra has told herself she wanted for four years. Now she is here, that goal is met – well, the competition is still looming, but she has no way of knowing what will happen on the day of – and without something else to focus on, she can't pretend that there wasn't always something else lurking in the background that she wanted. Adora was always right there at the edges of her mind. Now she is often lounging her bed.

They exchange information on a digital messaging app for while they're in the country and Adora texts her several times a day, asking if she wants to do this or that. She invites her to just about every place in the Olympic Village. And Catra, despite it being against her plans, *accepts*. She really planned to just see Adora for sex until they did their runs, but what Adora said about getting a redo on their first Olympics really stuck with her. If she wants to move on, what better way to do it than to reclaim everything that was taken from her before?

The fact that she wants to spend time with Adora is irrelevant. After all, sometimes it gets a little awkward, so that obviously can't be it. Sometimes it feels just like old times, but sometimes the gap

between them becomes painfully obvious and those *emotions* she's trying to avoid resurface. She should stop coming when Adora calls, but she just can't help it, even when it leaves her awkwardly fumbling and dropping the polaroid camera that Adora shoves her way. Catra hisses, mostly to herself, as she manages to catch it by pinning it between her wrists and holds it up for Adora to take away, glaring sullenly at her.

"*Right hand*, Adora," she grits out. Adora winces, taking the impulse purchase from her sheepishly and sending Catra a look so apologetic that she can only describe it as a puppy that has been recently kicked and doesn't know what they did to deserve it. Adora fidgets with the blank instant film, getting it set back in its proper place in the camera as she continues to send Catra apologetic looks.

"Sorry, I didn't realize you. Sorry," she murmurs. She sounds self-flagellating. Catra crosses her arms and looks away, just giving Adora a grunt of acknowledgment. She doesn't want Adora to languish in her guilt, she just also doesn't want to talk about it either, especially not in the middle of the shopping complex that was built into the Olympic village. They're just outside the little tech store where Adora bought the camera to "make memories." It definitely isn't the place to talk about this.

"So. Um, this seems like 'emotions', but." Adora trails off when Catra doesn't acknowledge her. Catra glares at a planter further down the shopping way. She's honestly surprised that Adora hasn't asked before now given the fact that they have fucked nearly every day now. In her daily life, it isn't so obvious, but the closest she has come to needing finesse in front of Adora has been when she touches her, and she doesn't doubt that Adora has noticed some of the difference in how she used to do that.

"Is your hand okay?" Adora finally commits to asking, her voice small and almost cringing, like she expects to be told off. Catra hasn't been nearly as short-tempered with her since they laid out their rules and fell into a rhythm, but this is definitely something that she is generally touchy about. Still, she's kind of tired of pretending the

answer is *yes*. Catra sighs, dropping her shoulders and turning back to face Adora. Adora's expression has barely changed, though there is a hopeful light to it as Catra lifts up her hand and flexes it for Adora to see.

A fist is easy. So is just leaving her pointer finger up. If she moves her second finger, though, her last two twitch up with it. She can't straighten out her last two fingers, at least not without something to press them against to physically force them up. She can't splay the last two either. Gripping things is easy once she has the object arranged in her hand, but spreading out her fingers to actually *grab* is a challenge. Adora watches Catra move her hand with a level of intensity that would only be necessary if she was going to be quizzed on it later – and for the results of that quiz to determine if a bus full of people survive dangling off a cliff.

"I never got full use of it back. That's my range of motion. I can grip ski poles fine, but some stuff is hard. My handwriting looks like shit now. And I can't totally feel the last two so they get, like, tangled up sometimes. I've learned to default to my left hand for a lot of things," Catra explains, dropping her hand down and crossing her arms again to tuck the offending hand away and out of sight. Adora nods quickly, sending Catra yet another apologetic look.

"I noticed you used your left hand for some things, but I thought it was just habit from when it was healing since I also saw you using your right. I shouldn't have assumed. I'll be more careful," Adora promises her. Catra sniffs, flicking an ear in acknowledgment. In truth her right hand is weaker than it used to be even with all her physical therapy, so she would have to use her left for some things even if she had full dexterity of it back. She can easily "fake" like she doesn't have any permanent effects, but if you spend time with her, it becomes more obvious.

She considers just leaving it at that, but she doesn't want to have this conversation again, or for Adora to go running back to her ice skater friends that she hangs out with when she isn't with Catra. Catra has spent a long time hiding the effects of her injury when she

is in the sports world and she doesnt need Adora ruining that for her when she has finally made it to the Olympics again and has a chance at some serious sponsorships. She is doing well enough repping magicat-specialty brands, but breaking into the wider market would help her a lot. Showing her injury where sponsors can see could be disastrous. She has to play the ableist's game if she wants to be able to afford to stay in her sport.

"That's what I want people to think, Adora. I can't afford a sponsor dropping me and I just want to put it behind me as much as I can," Catra points out. "Injuries aren't uncommon for athletes, so she isn't worried about the other competitors treating her differently or anything, but even without having sponsors to worry about, her injury and the recovery from it was a very dark time for her. She prefers not to think about it, and that's hard when people are bringing it up. There's a reason that she usually wears clothes that hide the scars on her chest and shoulder even when the weather is warm.

Adora looks pained, but she nods. She is clearly unhappy about it, but go figure, so is Catra. She breathes out a sigh, unfolding her arms and letting them drop by her sides again. She plans to ski for the rest of her life – the adrenaline rush she gets out on the slopes is incredible – but she knows that she will only be in competition shape for a few more years. Maybe after that, she can do an interview and tell the sports world to go fuck itself for how it treats disabilities, but for now she has to play along. Adora pauses for a long moment and then she pulls the camera strap over her head and, hands freed, cautiously reaches down.

"Can I?" she asks, softly, as the backs of their hands brush together. Catra feels her cheeks flush. She *should* say no, but holding hands as they walked around the village was definitely part of her plans for the first Olympics. They haven't done it in the last week that they have been exploring and dancing around each other. Besides, it's easier to hide her hand's issues when she is holding something and her fingers have a reason to be curled and motionless. Often she carries her phone in her hand even if she has pockets – in her

defense, she *is* often wearing leggings, even if most of her leggings for have pockets – but she supposes Adora's hand works to.

"Sure," Catra mumbles, looking away. She still sees Adora light up in her periphery. She would just grab Adora's hand and then she wouldn't have to say anything, but she is worried about her fingers getting tangled again. Some days are worse than others and it almost always gets worse around competitions. Some psychological bullshit, maybe, but it could just be that the more she uses it training and the like the more she has issues. Adora seems more than happy to take her hand, squeezing it gently before she gets bold and tries to thread their fingers together.

Catra's tail lashes as Adora does the work of weaving their fingers together. She might not be able to feel much beyond vague impressions in her last two fingers, a constant feeling of numbness spread through them, but she is starkly aware of Adora against the rest of her hand. Her hand is warm in Catra's, a foreign and yet so familiar feeling. Catra's only friend she would consider holding hands with doesn't *have* hands to hold, not to mention that they usually can only keep up with each other digitally as Catra travels for skiing and Scorpia travels for snowboarding. She hasn't really held hands with someone since she and Adora broke up – or since her accident.

It feels different. Adora offers her a small smile that is bursting with affection and excitement before she tugs on their hands, leading Catra through the shopping center. Absently, Catra tries to twitch her fingers. Adora squeezes back while pointing at a window display, already chattering a thousand miles a minute. Catra is sure that she is doing it to try to be casual and distract from their interwoven hands and honestly she is grateful. She wasn't expecting this to feel so *monumental*, but she usually tries to downplay the impact of her injury even to herself.

Adora squeezes her hand like it is nothing, but she is still so gentle. She glances down at their hands and beams as she leads Catra into the small boutique shop. She isn't having a moment like Catra is, her whole world seeming to shift a little, but she is obviously happy just

to be holding hands. Catra lets herself fall quiet and just listens to Adora pointing things out and chattering about how she bought a second suitcase after arriving to fill with souvenirs. It's very Adora and it makes Catra's lip twitch with a smile. She has missed her more than she even knew. That's saying a *lot*.

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Adora chokes on air when Catra first tells her that she has a sex schedule with her roommate. As much as it makes Adora's cheeks flush red, she is grateful for it. Their qualifying jumps aren't until day ten of the games and they both know that at that point they are going to part ways until the finals are done the day after. Adora doesn't know how she made it four years without Catra when less than forty-eight hours sound like torture to her now, but the week they get together leading up to the competition is a balm on her wounds.

They have a lot to talk about that they're just *ignoring* for the moment, but every other day Adora shows up at Catra's dorm and they fuck like they might never see each other again. Sometimes Adora sneaks Catra into her own dorm when she knows that her roommate will be away. One thing is for certain: whatever was going on in Catra's head that made her stay away for so long, the passion *never* died. When they're alone together, things get heated in the best way. At least, they do the first few days.

When the qualifiers draw near, Catra makes a joke about how they'll have to calm down in bed if they don't want to strain something and go into the competition sore. From how Catra reacted to the accidental claw marks that she left on Adora's hips, she doubts that it is really a joke. That is part of the reason that she feels bold enough to ask Catra to lay back for her when they meet in her room for the last time, but the handholding earlier that day bolstered her as well.

Catra didn't let go of her hand until they parted ways, Adora going to a late lunch with a judging Glimmer and Bow and Catra going to hang out with her snowboarder friend – who isn't even her

snowboarder roommate, it turns out. Adora's face when Mermista walked in on them still cuddling in the afterglow made her friend burst out laughing. Word traveled through their friend group fast and now Glimmer and Bow give her *looks* whenever they see her. The lecture she received aside, Adora is grateful that Mermista spends so much time out of the room, because it gives her the opportunity to do *this*.

She makes it clear even when they're just making out first that she wants to be in charge. Catra seems amused – though still turned on – by her assertiveness and she lets Adora get her settled back in the pillows, slowly pulling her clothes off and kissing the skin they leave exposed. Adora has a plan, but she isn't sure if it would be okay , or if Catra would even *like* it. Still, she feels like it is something she has to do. This certainly isn't the first time that she has thought about it, but it is the first time she has felt like Catra might allow it. Then again, this is definitely *emotions*.

"You planning on doing anything, Miss America, or just looking?" Catra teases from the pillows, though her voice is soft and warm. Adora remembers hating that nickname when Catra first started spitting it at her, but now she just smiles and ducks to press a kiss against the stripes on her thighs. Catra is naked now and Adora is topless. Catra had her bra off before Adora even started slipping her hands beneath Catra's clothes. Adora thinks that she has been plenty eager when it comes to kissing and touching Catra, but she hasn't made any attempts to move *past* that to something more.

"Oh, I have a plan," Adora assures, scattering a few kisses up to Catra's hip. She likes the slight divot beneath the bone and she *especially* likes to nuzzle against her luxuriously soft stomach. It's even better at this time of year, dense and silky. Catra's tail, draped off the edge of the bed, flicks with curiosity. Adora looks up to find Catra watching her with interest. If she said something like that the first time they hooked up, she thinks that Catra would have been suspicious, but now she just watches Adora with bright-eyed excitement.

Adora takes her time making her way up Catra's torso, kissing along the faint stripes that only seem to appear along Catra's sides in winter. Catra arches her back pointedly, pushing her breasts up, and Adora grins as she skips right over them. Catra huffs, her tail thudding once against the bed, as Adora presses a kiss right over her heart and then makes her way to the unscarred side of her neck, pressing a few soft kisses there. Finally, she shifts up so they are face-to-face. Despite Catra's huff, she doesn't look annoyed. She just seems to be relaxed and waiting for the most part. Adora cautiously places her left hand on Catra's right bicep, massaging it gently.

"Can I kiss your scars?" she asks, her voice low. Catra's eyes widen, her tail immediately lashing. Adora ignores it as it whips around and hits her calves, maintaining eye contact as she continues her gentle ministrations with her hands. "I get if you don't want me to. But I want to show every part of you love," she adds, realizing that was probably *too much* when Catra flushes a violent shade and gives a small squeak, quickly looking away. Adora bites her lip, moving back a little just to give Catra room to breathe, but she doesn't let go, switching to softly petting down Catra's arm instead.

From what Catra said in the mall, Adora would guess that she doesn't give the injured parts of her love often. Knowing Catra, she is probably frustrated with them a lot. Adora didn't realize that anything was wrong with her left hand since she has often seen her holding things in it, but after seeing her range of motion and looking back on how Catra uses it, she has come to realize that it is a covering mechanism. She hates that Catra feels like she has to do stuff like that. She wants to show her appreciation as much as she wants to refamiliarize herself with her body.

Adora hasn't *avoided* her scars, but she hasn't paid them any attention either. She was worried Catra wouldn't like it. On the third day, she tried to kiss that side of Catra's neck and Catra redirected her to the uninjured side with a hand on the back of her head. Given Catra's obvious reluctance to talk about her injury – ever since they

talked, she has been willing to answer questions about how her life is now, but not any related to what it was like a few years ago or her healing process – Adora didn't want to force the issue and make her uncomfortable.

Now, she is hoping that Catra might like it. If not, she can just say no. Catra takes several seconds to think about it, looking away the entire time and lashing her tail back and forth as she does. Her face is scarlet and Adora *swears* she hears a slight rumble coming from her, but whether or not that is a growl or a purr is yet to be determined. Eventually, Catra looks back at her, although she fixes her gaze on Adora's ear rather than looking her in the eye. She shifts a little in the sheets, as if uncomfortable, and then grumbles loud enough for Adora to be sure of what she heard.

"I won't be able to feel much of it," she warns. Adora blinks down at her, her hand automatically stilling before she remembers to resume her petting.

"That's okay," she assures. "As long as it's okay with you, I mean. I can't imagine what it must be like to not feel your own body," she quickly tacks on. She doesn't know if the loss of sensation bothers Catra. Well, Adora doesn't doubt that she would *prefer* to be able to feel everything, but she doesn't know if it freaks her out to be able to see something touch her and not actually feel it. Catra's ear flicks.

"It's fine. I think. We can try it, at least," Catra returns. Adora knows that she is *definitely* doing that thing where she plays down her emotions, but she thinks that Catra might actually want this and not just be tolerating it. *We can try* implies that she wants it to work, at least to Adora. What Catra wants to get out of this, she doesn't know, but she hopes it is a little bit of that peace that Adora wants to bring her. Carefully, Adora shifts her hand on Catra to hold her arm steady and then bends down, pressing a kiss to Catra's scar right above her armpit.

Catra's breathing goes uneven.

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As much as Catra doesn't want her injury to define her, she is *tired* of pretending that it doesn't exist. In some ways, it feels as limiting as constantly talking about it. She feels it, but she doesn't, when Adora's lips brush against her scar. She thinks she feels as much with her scar tissue as Scorpia does on her chitin – the impression of a touch, but none of the finer details. Adora's lips would feel the same as any other object of the same size. Adora could poke her with a pencil or a baby carrot and Catra wouldn't be able to tell. At least, that would be true if her eyes were closed. *Seeing* Adora dip her head down and kiss the scar is really what makes her gasp out.

She feels next to nothing in her scar. She feels fucking *everything* in her heart. She drops her head back against the pillow, having raised it a little to watch, and focuses on her breathing as Adora pauses. Her free hand finds its way to Catra's side, petting along her softly. The touch is soothing, just like Adora is in general. Well, okay, she often sets Catra's blood on fire – for a few years there, in the worst way, but all along the best kind of fire was underlying it and that is all that Catra has felt for days now – but Adora always has a strong effect on her.

Right now it kind of feels like Adora has a fist wrapped around her heart and is squeezing it as hard as she can, but Catra is pretty sure that she isn't having a heart attack and this is just called having feelings. Maybe Adora will squeeze out all the poison that has been pumped into her veins – by Shadow, by faceless sports writers, by Catra herself – and she can figure out how to soak in the warmth of Adora's light without the constant fear that she is about to be burned.

Adora kisses her again, she thinks. It feels like she does, but her gaze is fixed up on the ceiling, so it's hard to tell. Maybe Adora just brushes up against her. Catra's throat feels tight for no good reason as Adora holds her steady and kisses her way up the length of the scar. Near the middle, around where Adora started, it is the most visible and numb, at least barring the point where her collarbone came through. As Adora works her way up, Catra feels the touch a

bit more, able to make out the shape of both her lips in the loving kisses that she leaves, even if anything could be leaving those two impressions with her none the wiser.

All that feeling goes away when Adora kisses her collarbone. Catra lets out a small whine without meaning to, causing Adora to freeze above her. Quickly, Catra untangles her good hand from the sheets – she doesn't even know when she started fisting them – and reaches up to cradle the back of Adora's head and direct her to the center of her chest. She lets out a wet gasp when Adora understands her and immediately kisses her there. Even with her dense winter coat, Catra can feel that – although now that she thinks about it, the gap between how it feels through her coat and how it feels on her bare scar isn't as big as she always thought it was.

"Shh, it's alright. We can stop. I'll be right here," Adora assures her, reaching up and cupping her cheek. Catra makes a strangled noise in her throat, the closest to a *no* she can get right then, but she cuts off when Adora gently wipes her thumb beneath the corner of her eye and she realizes that she started crying. Not like, *really* really crying, but a tear slipped out. She turns her head into Adora's palm, breathing deeply and trying to calm herself despite how her heartbeat is racing.

What the fuck was she *ever* doing fighting with Adora? She doesn't think it has ever hit her before that she didn't have to struggle through her recovery alone. The sports world had already written her off and no one was paying attention to her. She wasn't proving anything to anyone but *herself* when she insisted on being on her own and clawing her way back to her old life. Adora was always an integral part of that life, but somewhere along the way Catra lost that and all she could see was the Olympic podium – and every medal that Adora earned in a higher place than her.

With Adora before her, though, she just feels *cared for*. It's something that she hasn't really felt since she was discharged from her last rehab center, and even then she was resistant to rely on *anybody*. She only accepted the nurses' help because she knew it

was her best chance of building her strength back up and being able to re-enter her sport. Having proved herself, though, she doesn't feel like she has to bristle beneath Adora's touch the way that she did merely at being the subject of her gaze for the last few years.

"Did you ever pity me?" Catra gasps out, screwing her eyes shut. She feels another tear fall, once again quickly brushed away by Adora. Adora shifts both her hands up to frame her face, gently petting her cheeks with her thumbs.

"No. I worried a lot and I was *angry* for you – and sometimes at you – but I didn't pity you. I mean, I felt bad that it happened, but I feel that way any time someone gets injured," Adora replies. Catra swallows. She doesn't know if she can convince herself to believe that – and she isn't sure that what Adora has already admitted to is all that different from pity – but she feels...something, at least. Something not awful.

"Did you ever hate me?" she asks next. She is breaking all her rules – on the night *before qualifiers*, the second worst possible time that she could – but she needs to know. She has assumed the answer for years. Adora makes a small noise. It sounds pained, but that doesn't seem right.

"*No*, Catra. I was mad sometimes, but mostly it just...hurt. I missed you. I knew some of why you were mad at me, but I didn't know where I went wrong along the way to make you feel like that and I just...I wanted you back," Adora replies, her voice starting strong and sure, but by the end she is whispering. Catra is crying now and there's no going back. Adora continues to gently wipe her tears away. Adora is *too* understanding with her. She really doesn't feel like she deserves it.

"You didn't do anything. Maybe occasionally you could have said something that would have slowed it down, but...that Shadow bitch just pumped my head full of insults and insecurities. The articles that came out after my injury fucked with my head even more, and you weren't there, and I...I had fucking *nothing*. When you came back, all

Iheard was that you wanted to leave and you didnt care about my career anymore – that you didnt care about *me* or what Iwanted for myself,"Catra manages, her words rough and halting, but they have been building in her for years. The noise Adora makes now is so clearly wounded that Catra cant talk herself out of it.

"Catra, that was never what it was about. Ijust wanted to get us away from Shadow. t was a guaranteed of fer for one of us at least and Iknew that was the best we were going to get then. Ididnt want you to think that Ionly cared about how you preformed or that I would love you any less if you did end up disabled. Ijust..really fucked up communicating that,"Adora tells her , tone desperate and squeezing her cheeks a little as she talks.

Catra is pretty sure that she's just emotional and needs to do something with her hands. Catra doesnt mind. t feels grounding. She is emotionally fragile – bordering on threatening to shatter – but fuck does she need to hear Adora lay it out like that. She has come to suspect pretty much everything Adora just said, but it was hard to accept logic retroactively, especially when their fight broke as bad as it did. That was Catra' s fault.

She pushed Adora, trying to get her to admit that she didnt want Catra if she wasnt competing or that she never wanted Catra to heal up enough to compete with her again. Those two ideas were a little counterintuitive, but she was sure one of them was right, and she threw accusations at Adora until Adora was yelling back. t doesnt take much to rile her up, but Catra was determined that Adora hated her as much as she hated herself and she would have kept pushing until she got her proof.

"Thank you. And Im sorry ,"Catra whispers back. Her eyes are still screwed up – she is afraid that if she opens them then shell start bawling – but after a moment she feels a soft kiss against the wrinkle in her brow.

"Iam too. Y ou were going through so much and Ishouldnt have risen to it. We can talk about it more later,"Adora promises her ,

kissing her nose now. Her voice is a bit rough too – Catra isn't the only one affected by this conversation – but she stays steady for Catra. Unlike four years ago, Adora knows what she needs now and she grounds her as Catra works to keep from breaking into sobs. She wants to shove her emotions down and lock them away until the Games are over, but she knows that she can't do that.

No emotions was a hopeless rule. They were never going to follow it. Catra leans her head forward, nuzzling into Adora, and Adora takes the hint and shifts to wrap her arms around, cradling her close and holding her. Catra's breath is still ragged and she is certain this isn't what Adora had planned for them, but they definitely both needed it. If they want to avoid full-on sobbing and wearing themselves out before their runs tomorrow, they need to stop here.

They went far enough that Catra isn't *terrified* of the full conversation when they have it. She isn't looking forward to it by any means and she is definitely going to cry a lot, but it doesn't feel like everything that they have managed to build over the last few days will come shattering apart at the slightest resistance now.

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They never end up having sex. It just isn't right. Adora was planning to get there after the kisses, but *sex* and *crying* don't go together unless the tears are just from how good it feels. They cuddled for a long time and it felt like a special kind of intimacy to redress her lover without any intentions except caring for her. She *thinks* Catra is her lover again, at least. That is definitely a question for after the competition. They are repairing bridges, though, and Adora already knows that they are incapable of acting platonic with each other.

Adora was totally fine with not having sex last night, but she kind of wishes that they would in the morning just to deal with the pre-competition nerves. She is mostly excited, but it being her second Olympics doesn't lower the pressure any. She can't imagine what Catra is feeling giving everything riding on this – both actual pressures, like sponsorships, and personally fabricated, like the

deep need to prove herself that Adora never realized was there until they were breaking up.

They text each other in the morning as they get food, but they both need to keep their head in the game, and that means not getting caught up in each other, so they don't even see each other. They also have interviews to do, reporters calling for attention wherever they go once they have left the haven of the Olympic village. Adora has kind of been *distracted* for the past week with Catra and though she was still excited to get out and compete, it hasn't been on the top of her mind. It has to be once they arrive to do their qualifying jumps.

The thing is, Adora knows that on her average day doing qualifying jumps might as well be equivalent to going for a scenic ski down the mountainside for most others – even for some of the people here today. She consistently makes Top 10 lists for athletes in her sport and even sometimes onto lists for winter sport athletes in general. She has had a meteoric rise to success – at least that's what the articles say, not accounting for the fact that she started skiing before she could even read.

All that is to say, even putting in a half-assed effort she should qualify. The problem is that she is always very aware of what can go wrong and how it can ruin you. Injuries are common in freestyle skiing and she had even witnessed them before or had them herself before Catra's major accident – she and Catra both bore some scars and broken bones, though mostly minor, starting from a young age – but witnessing an injury like that changed her.

An article once questioned if she could really be considered a top athlete if she sometimes pulls out of competitions on the day of finals. The consensus in the sports world – and even amongst her own trainers – is that when she is skiing, she is brilliant, but sometimes she *can't ski*. Sometimes she cant get out of her hotel room even because she is having panic attacks with visions of Catra's broken body before her, her right arm twisted at multiple

unnatural angles and chest pouring blood. Adora thought that Catra was going to die in her arms.

No one has ever put together that she almost never pulls out of a competition that Catra is also in, though. Adora may have her panic attacks still, but she will get her ass to the hill no matter what because she has to see Catra jump. Once she is there, she can usually handle it and go through with everything. She isn't afraid of having a breakdown at the Olympics – and besides, Catra *is* here, waiting and having made it clear that she wants them to go head-to-head – but that fear means that she takes even simple competition rounds seriously.

After all, if she does well she is all but guaranteed a spot. If she has an accident, though, that would likely be it for her Olympics and could even be it for her career. She takes every competition and every run seriously. She kind of has the opposite attitude towards them that Catra *seems* to project. Catra is often light-hearted and joking before the event. After the runs begin though, she gets deadly quiet. *Competitive*. If she has a good first run – well, if she has a better one than Adora – she will continue to be bright, almost vivacious. If not, she retreats and any attempts to draw her out of her shell will only cause her to lash out.

This is the first time in years that they have been at the top of the hill and chatted amicably as they wait. Adora feels a few skiers – specifically ones that have been at competitions with them before – give them looks as they chat, clearly noticing the absent rivalry that Adora is *pretty* sure hasn't made its way past rumor amongst the other athletes, but who knows, there could be articles online. Adora doesn't care about the looks. It helps to calm her anxiety to talk to Catra. She is standing before her as living proof that even when a horrific accident like that happens, you can walk away from it and get back on the slopes.

"Good luck kiss?" Catra teases her as she prepares to take her place the top of the hill. If she means it purely as a joke, she should know better than to try to make one like that around Adora. Adora eagerly

leans forward, taking a second to find a good angle, but after a few seconds she manages to tilt her head in a way that lets her kiss Catra's cheek even with their helmets and Catra's goggles in the way. Adora sees her blush around the edges of them.

"Good luck," Adora tells her, grinning as Catra's tail lashes behind her. Catra, in typical Catra fashion, chooses to deal with her emotions by lightly punching Adora's arm and grumbling as she skis away to get in her position. Adora can feel eyes on her, and for all she knows some cameraman filmed that, but she doesn't see one of the big TV cameras in her immediate vicinity and she is too busy grinning from ear to ear to look around and check.

It already happened anyway. She is too busy basking in it to care.

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They each get three qualifying runs. Only their best score is kept. Catra goes easy on her first two. She would rather post a decent score that leaves her middle of the pack and at risk of pruning than get injured early and flunk out. For her final run, she pushes herself a little more. She *needs* to take enough risk to secure her spot in the finals, but she doesn't want to use everything that she has today. She posts a good score. She is talking to a reporter afterwards when Adora is finishing up her own runs.

"Looks like you were playing it a bit safe out there today. Are you worried about a repeat of the injury that ended your last Olympics early or do you not think about it anymore?" the reporter asks. Part of Catra hates when reporters pry into this part of her life, but she also appreciates it when they have at least done enough homework to ask. Injuries are just normal in the sports world. On the surface, she doesn't think a lot of people realize how different her injury was. Even permanently disabling injuries are normal, but the people who receive them usually aren't still capable of making it to the Olympics. Of course reporters assume it's like asking about any other accident.

"There's no need to overexert myself during qualifiers. I just want to secure my spot. Tomorrow you'll see me give it my all," Catra returns, skipping over the injury question. The only part of her exposed right now is her face. Her scars from the accident are hidden. The reporter gives a little laugh, but Catra is distracted when she hears the unmistakable click of dozens of shutters that signals somebody else making their run.

"You have enough confidence in your abilities that you're comfortable not giving your all even at the Olympics?" the reporter asks, but Catra has done the mental math in her head of who was next up and ignores her, instead turning to catch sight of Adora nearly halfway down the slope in the middle of flip. Catra's breath hitches. She always loves watching Adora fly, almost as much as she enjoys doing it herself. From this angle, the landing looks good – clean, and she still has decent speed – but Catra would have to see the tape to really tell.

The reporter doesn't try to recapture her attention as Adora goes into her next jump, twisting cleanly in the air. That jump Catra is confident is *textbook*. It's a gold-worthy performance. There is a reason that Adora is at the top of her sport. As she skis to the bottom of the hill, banking to cut her momentum, Catra grins to herself. She loves being able to watch without worrying about being caught looking. There have never been more cameras around, but it doesn't matter if anyone sees her watching now.

Adora has another run to go still, but even only seeing some of the run, Catra thinks that she might have a spot in the finals. Adora's smile has she looks up for the score is enough to tell her that and she never goes less than a hundred percent anyway. Catra thinks her strategy is smarter, but she loves to watch Adora regardless. As Adora moves out of the way for the next run, she catches sight of Catra. Catra watches her reach up to move her goggles onto her forehead, revealing the bright look in her eye as she grins at Catra and skis over to her instead.

"You've got another run to finish, Grayskull, get your ass back up to the top," Catra calls to her when Adora gets close enough that she doesn't actually have to shout. Adora, like a mature adult, sticks her tongue out and skis up to Catra's side, making her way around Catra to park beside her on her left side so they are as close as you can comfortably get on skis. Catra is aware of all the cameras on them, but she finds herself drawn in by Adora like she often is and she doesn't think twice about nudging back when Adora checks her with her shoulder.

"Were you watching?" Adora asks, breathless excitement still in her voice from the adrenaline. Catra rolls her eyes.

"Just saw the second half. Get back up there if you want me to see a full run," Catra tells her , elbowing her gently in her ticklish spot around her ribs. Even with all the layers of padding, Adora giggles, scooting back with the assistance of her ski poles to flee from Catra's arms' reach. It is nearly zero degrees outside, but Catra's entire body is feeling a bit hot from the warmth in her chest as she watches Adora's sparkling expression.

"Alright, fine, but you better watch!" Adora agrees, blowing Catra a kiss before she turns and skis away. For maybe the first time in her life, Catra is glad that her helmet cramps her ears. It means no one can see the way they twitch. She watches Adora ski away only long enough to gather herself before she turns and faces the reporter again. The reporter's expression is nothing short of delighted. Catra already knows that clip will be on YouTube before dinner. The sports world loves interactions between their favorites almost as much as they love interaction between rivals. Adora just happens to qualify as both.

"What is it like to be competing against your former teammate?" the reporter asks with a spark in her eye. Catra pauses. She isn't sure what to really say to that. It depends what the reporter is counting as *teammates*. Probably just the fact they were both on Team USA once.

"We grew up training together, so I guess it's just normal. It doesn't matter what flag she flies, she's still Adora. I want to take home that top spot, but there's plenty of other competition out there to consider too," Catra replies. She doesn't want to sound *too* cocky. She is confident in her ability to secure a finals slot, but the actual competition will be a lot closer. It isn't like she and Adora are the only people here, even if a lot people are looking at Adora as the favorite and thus the one to beat. Catra knows a few of her competitors also consider her stiff competition – at least, they *should* – but she doubts that she is the general public's top pick.

"There's okay. She took awhile to heal up and she has been holding back lately to make sure she stayed in shape for the Games. People can think that she has already peaked all they want – she is determined to show them wrong tomorrow. She has three runs. She has ambitious plans for them, but her last one especially will see her go all out. If she fails – hell, if she breaks her fucking collarbone again – she will have done what she came to do.

"No hard feelings now that she has left for Canada?" the reporter pushes. Catra resists the urge to scowl. She knows some of their antagonism towards each other has made it online – there are rumors of a rivalry between them, at least – so she can't lie and say no, but she doubts this reporter knows about that. She just wants a good story and lots of views.

"It's been four years. Our history is more important than that," she settles on saying. It isn't a yes and it isn't a no. To those who know, it will confirm that she felt that way once but got over it. To those that don't, it will be more ambiguous, but they could even take it as a no. That works for her. She is about done giving juicy tidbits to the random camera that got stuck in her face. She'll be having a press conference with the rest of the US ski team tomorrow after the finals anyway. Anything they want to pester her about can wait until then.

She doesn't immediately walk away – that would be too dramatic and telling – but she quickly finds an excuse to leave the

conversation. Besides, she wants to be able to watch all of Adora's next run.

Chapter End Notes

AFTER this fic is done, I'm probably gonna go on hiatus while I work on personal projects for a bit, but who knows, inspiration could strike. Updates will be on my tumblr as always.

The Closing Ceremonies

Chapter Notes

> I have no idea what determines the order that people compete in the Olympics or if it varies by sport and I'm not interested in finding out so I just made some shit up lol
> *This was supposed to be a 5k one shot.*

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They both make it to the finals. Catra is pretty low on the list and Adora is in second, but they make it. It reflects the effort that they put into their jumps, really. Adora is a little concerned that she is currently in silver when she knows that Catra at least was playing it safe and others may be as well, but she always tries to make competing about what she can do out there and not the medals. She wants to do *incredible* things – she wants to fly, flip, grind, and rocket down the slopes – and those things often rack up points and get her medals, but she does her best not to cry herself to sleep when she doesn't win.

Alright, focusing on having fun in the moment isn't mutually exclusive with crying in her hotel room and she often finds herself doing it on the occasions that she doesn't podium – or if she does, but not high enough for her brain to stop whispering *failure* to her. She is trying, though. She has been coached on this many times but it is hard to kick completely. She does interviews after her runs and she manages to be cheerful and optimistic, but as she heads back for the Olympic village, she feels the old insecurities and perfectionism kicking in.

Most people would kill for a silver medal at the Olympics, she tries to tell herself, because even as her mind tells her she is going to fail, her heart tells her that she is privileged and whining about nothing. It is a thought that she often has whenever something goes wrong in a

competition. Memories of Catra's accident come up and she wonders how she can be making such a big deal out of everything when she is still well enough to get up and try again tomorrow. She is pretty sure that Catra would hate her thinking that way, though. She wouldnt want to be an example.

Adora really doesnt want to go back to her room to be alone, but she doesnt think that she is allowed to see Catra now . They have almost twenty-four hours until they make their final runs and Adora knows that she is going to spend a significant portion of that worrying – at least for the rest of today, anyway. Usually her anxiety settles down overnight and she wakes up on the day of the competition with her head on straight until the next time that it flares up.

She decides to text Catra. t might be pushing, but maybe it will still be acceptable. She holds her phone in her hand, jttering her leg up and down, as she waits for a response. She could go find Glimmer and Bow to occupy her if Catra wont talk to her , but she wants it to be Catra. Besides, Glimmer has her short program skate tonight and she is going to be busy. She doesnt need to be dealing with Adora' s anxiety on top of her own. No one needs to be dealing with Adora's anxiety, but unfortunately *she* is going to be if she doesnt manage to calm it before it gets bad.

Her phone chimes. Adora scrambles to check it. She breathes out a sigh of relief when she sees that Catra has offered for them to meet up for food. They are both athletes and they could *always* eat, but right now Adora cares more about the company than the calories. She sends back a message agreeing immediately. As soon as her phone makes the sent message notification sound, she breathes a bit easier. The last time that she was at the Olympic games, she almost threw up from nerves – and general anxiety – before the finals. She would much rather be spending the evening with Catra.

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They meet up for lunch – or brunch, or dinner , Catra doesn't fucking know at this point, she's just hungry – and they just talk about light things while they eat. Catra wasn't planning on spending any time with Adora in person between the qualifiers and finals, but Adora sounded like she needed it over text, and Catra is glad that she agreed to meet up when she sees her in person and reads the stress on her. Hanging out seems to help. They eat, wander around the village a bit, get snacks, chat about gear for a while, and get food again – they're athletes, alright, they need a lot of calories – before finally they part ways after sunset.

Adora seems a lot better for it. Catra enjoyed it too. It helped her take her mind off the upcoming finals. She isn't afraid of an injury , except she totally is. Injuries are common in freestyle skiing, even at the Olympic level. One of the girls who didn't make it into finals landed wrong and twisted her ankle – which is honestly *mild* as far as injuries on the slopes go – and one of the men doing their run after the women's group injured his leg, maybe even broke it, though Catra didn't hear what the diagnosis ended up being and she isn't googling it. There will be articles by now , but she doesn't need to stress herself.

She has made it to the finals at the Olympics. That needs to be the only thing that matters to her. Everybody said she couldn't get this far for years. Those predictions only started turning around in the last year or two. She has shown them wrong, but the work isn't done. It feels like her entire life has been building up to this. She struggles to fall asleep, in her own head with both excitement and anxiety. She keeps telling herself that she will be fine with having made it if she doesn't podium tomorrow . She knows that isn't true, though.

Then she tries to tell herself that she will be fine with placing above Adora, but that feels cruel. The fact is Adora is definitely the one to beat. If Catra can place above her , then clearly whoever else managed to podium above *both* of them was stiff competition. Catra knows the statistics on Olympic winners, though. Supposedly bronze

medalists are happiest. Gold medalists are stressed, feeling like they have nowhere else to go but down. Silver medalists were so close, they are often consumed by the little failures that held them back. Bronze medalists get the joy of reaching the podium while still having room to grow.

Catra can't help but wonder what Adora thinks of those statistics. She got bronze at her last Olympics, after all, and she has said in interviews her goal this time is to beat that. If she does, will she eventually find that she was happier last time? Actually, Catra is sure that she won't given everything else going on at the time. She doesn't think that she would personally be happiest in bronze regardless of what the statistics say. She *knows* that she is at her peak right now.

This is her only chance to take home *any* medal. She wants the gold. She is confident that she is good enough to earn it, but no matter how good you are on *average*, you can still have three bad runs on any competition day and utterly fail. Her heart races at the very thought. Not here. Not today, not tomorrow, and not at the Olympics. She can't know what will happen or what emotions she will feel tomorrow, but she knows that she won't be playing it safe on any of her runs.

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"How'd you sleep?" Adora asks as they stand at the top of the hill, waiting for their first runs. She will be one of the last to go – at least for her first run – given how high that she placed in qualifiers, but Catra will be one of the first. They are all waiting to begin the very first runs of the day, though, so they have a little time to kill.

"Took a long time to fall asleep, but I didn't toss and turn. You?" Catra replies. She is gruff, but she is at least engaging back. Her

eyes are fixed out on the slope.

“About the same, but Iwoke up a little early too. Y ou know how I am,”she returns, shrugging. Catra grunts and nods. Adora’ s routine for before a competition hasnt changed and she is sure that Catra knows it well even after four years. f the competition is spread over multiple days, Adora will be able to jıst have fun and be excited for qalifiers and semifinals, but she starts getting anxious the night before finals. She tends to wake up early and spend the morning alternatively stretching and eating to fuel up. Catra could roll out of her bed, into her skis, and right down the hill without worrying about it affecting her abilities, but Adora feels like she needs hours to prep.

“Hey , Adora,”Catra prompts from beside her . Adora startles, realizing she was getting caught up in her own head again. She really needs to not do that during competitions. Part of what she loves about skiing is it lets her let go of her anxiety and jıst enjoy herself while she is making her way down the slope. Catra still isnt looking at her, watching the glimmering white of the snow stretching out below her.

“Y eah?”Adora asks, finding herself swaying a bit closer to where Catra is parked beside her. Well, actually Adora is the one who skied up to her, but details. Finally, Catra looks away from the slope to send Adora a mischievous look.

“Let’ s fuck with our medals on tonight,”Catra says, her voice low and a wicked smirk on her lips. Adora’s mouth gapes open as Catra, apparently satisfied, *skis away*, leaving Adora to stand alone and try to force her brain to process those words.

She needs to fucking podium.

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Catra played it safe in qualifiers. She isn't doing that in the finals. She wants every one of her runs to have the viewers tuning into the Games dropping their jaws and asking *do people really do this?* She goes fast, rocketing down the hill. She goes *hard*, tucking herself in and flipping through the air as she flies off the ramps. When she grinds on the rails, all she is thinking about is reaching the next ramp and landing cleanly.

Her form isn't perfect. She lands with her right ski rather crooked on the final jump but manages to correct it. She skis into the finish area with her heart pounding. To the casual viewer, it will look thrilling, but to the trained eye she needs to do *better*. She may love pushing for speed when she is skiing purely for pleasure, but it was just a little too out of control. She reviews the entire run in her head when she gets back up to the top. She is in first place right now, but when only a few people have done their first runs, that means nothing.

Adora tries to talk to her once she has made her way up from her own initial run, but she quickly retreats when she sees the look on Catra's face. Now is when she needs to concentrate. She has the adrenaline in her now. She has had time to adjust to its presence and she had the first run to practice. This time will be the real deal. She takes a deep breath before she shoots down the hill for her second run. *Form*, she repeats in her head. Tight control.

The problem is that her control over her own body was partially robbed from her in the accident. She can't let it affect her skiing though. She tells herself that she just needs momentum to do her twists. Her shoulder can't hold her back – her hand can't. She throws herself into every movement, determined to commit no matter what. She pulls her signature move of barely looking behind her when she skis backwards the slope. It's show-offy, but when she has run a course before she can usually pull it off, and it helps her speed. She goes into her backwards ramp without any issue.

She executes her triple cork perfectly. She hears yells from the watching crowd as she goes down into her final jump, but her ski slips a little beneath her and she doesn't have the momentum to do

the full trick. She has to adjust, going for fewer rotations. Overall the run is better than her first, but it's not the best. When the scores come back, she's in silver behind Adora with about half of the attempts left to go. It could be that no one posts a better time, but after all the runs are done, it also could be that it isn't enough to even podium.

She is in her own head, but she manages to watch Adora's second run. Catra's angle isn't great and she can't fully assess how well Adora does, but she almost seems to float through the air as she does her jumps. She grinds harder than Catra did, throwing herself into it and twisting when she is in the air. All Catra can think is *I hope I look like that when I'm flying*. She is entrancing to watch. Near the bottom of the hill, Catra loses sight of her entirely, but her heart is pounding with thrill just from what she did manage to catch as she gets in position to wait for her final run.

Adora makes it back to the top before it's time for Catra to get up to the starting line. She skates up to Catra, switching both poles to one hand and holding out her free hand hopefully. She has her goggles up on her forehead and she looks at Catra with wide, hopeful eyes. Catra should ignore her, but instead she softly curses and then goes through the complicated process of removing her safety loop and transferring her right pole over to her left hand without getting her fingers bent. Eventually she manages it and Adora reaches out, carefully slipping their gloved hands together.

"You look amazing when you fly like that. I want to see what you can do when you put together the moves from both those runs," she tells her, gently squeezing Catra's hand. Catra twitches her fingers and then squeezes back, her heart pounding. She wants to see that too. She wants Adora to look at her and feel the same heart-pounding that Catra feels when she watches her.

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Adora hears the calls after Catra has crested out of her sight over the ramp and has a mini heart attack, but they seem excited, not horrified, and a moment later she skis back into view and hops onto the rail. Maybe she managed the full trick and that was awe, or maybe she landed sloppy and recovered, but Adora does get to see her do the full triple cork again and the speed that Catra has takes her breath away. What she sees of the run is flawless, but she doesnt have time to check the score when she has to get in position herself. She hopes it was enough to push Catra further up the podium. She was hovering around bronze last that Adora saw .

She is pretty happy with her first two runs. She thinks she has a shot of staying up top. Her first run was better than her second, but only by a little. She was in gold using her first score last that she checked. There have been more runs since then though, so for all that she knows she has been bumped to twelfth. The odds are almost impossible, but she cant get complacent. Catra seems too caught up in her own head, so Adora was distracted from her own performance when she got up to the top and just wanted to comfort her, but as she prepares for her final run she thinks: what would Catra want to watch?

Catra likes speed. She likes daring flips. She likes moments where you think that there's no way that the skis are going to get parallel to the ground in time to stick the landing. She likes her heart to pound while she is skiing or watching. All those things tend to make for great scores – at least as long as your form is good – so Catra tends to score well doing the things that she loves. No matter where they end up placing, though, Adora wants Catra to have had *fun* today, so she wants to give her something to watch.

Adora can go faster than Catra thanks to her increased mass, but she usually doesnt. More speed may make getting in more rotations easier, but it is also harder to control and leaves less time for split second adjustments. Her first time was good though. Now is the time to take a risk. This run isnt about scoring: it' s about Catra. She gets

the go signal and she shoots herself down the slope. She wants to break a speed record today – and hopefully not any bones.

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Catra gets to watch Adora's final run from the bottom of the hill. She doesnt get a clear view of her as she goes into the ramps, but she gets to see her *fly* off them. She shot out like a canon from the top of the hill, even going lighter on the rails than she usually does to maintain her speed. She flies off the ramps and Catra catches herself starting forward, just wanting to be *closer*. She loses some of the perfect form that she is known for with the reckless wildness of her run, but Catra's heart leaps watching it.

This is the style of skiing that Catra is known for , and it isnt necessarily the best one for the Olympics, but fuck, she *loves* it. Adora might as well have written *I love you* in the snow. Catra's heart is pounding as Adora skis into the final area and nervously looks up to watch for the score. She cant re-enter the finish area to talk to Adora, but she skis closer so that she can greet Adora the second that she gets out. She watches the scoreboard herself, but she is pretty sure that Adora isnt going to best her first score with a run like that.

That run wasnt *for* the scoreboard, though. That was for the thrill. That was for Catra and no matter how many times that she thinks it, her heart isnt going to stop pounding at the thought. Catra' s final run put her in first. No one else has beat her yet and there are very few runs left, but for once she isnt even thinking about the medals. She watches Adora's face as she sees the score, smiling and shrugging before turning and blowing a kiss to the camera near her face. She skis toward the exit and makes eye contact with Catra.

Her face lights up far more than it did when she watched the scoreboard. She puts real effort into her poles, propelling herself forward so that she can reach Catra. Catra's goggles are hanging around her neck. Adora's are on her forehead. Their skis are in the way too, so they have to park alongside each other and lean over. Everything about the kiss is awkward, but it feels right when they suck in the harsh mountain air and meet in the middle, finding only burning heat in the other's mouth.

"That was fucking *incredible*," Catra praises when they pull apart. Her voice is excitable even to her own ears. Adora breaks into a beaming smile, her eyes crinkling as she wraps her arm around Catra's shoulder and squeezes her close.

"Your triple cork was gorgeous. I can't wait to see the video of that full run. You're so thrilling to watch," Adora gushes in return, still breathless. She releases Catra to reach up and undo her helmet. Catra has already ditched hers and handed it off. Adora undoes the pin holding her ponytail on top of her head and shakes it out, still grinning down at Catra with flushed cheeks.

"You're in gold. I think it's nearly impossible for you to not get it now," she says. She sounds more excited about it than Catra has heard in *years*. Catra's stomach does a flip. She knows – she has been watching the scores closely – but Adora saying it makes it *real*. She wants this so badly, but she never gets the things that she wants. She didn't expect to *get it*. Her chin drops down and she stares down at her hands on the ski poles.

"Help me," she breathes, reaching up and holding her right hand out to Adora. She can see Adora looking at her curiously, but she reaches out and takes off the safety tether for Catra. Catra does nothing but carefully release the pole, letting Adora take it from her. Adora whistles, looking up, and Catra is aware of some member of Team Canada coming running up behind them that Adora passes off her helmet, her goggles, and Catra's pole too. Catra swallows, looking at the hand that she is still holding out.

gloves too. For us both. Unless you're going to freeze to death," Catra tells her. Adora quickly turns her head back to Catra, tilting it slightly, but she follows orders, unfastening Catra's glove and carefully straightening out her fingers as she pulls it off for her. Catra finally helps, reaching over with her left hand and taking the glove to tuck into her jacket so Adora will have her hands free to pull off her own glove. When Adora does so, Catra holds her hand up. Adora understands her without her needing to ask this time.

She reaches up and carefully intertwines her fingers with Catra's own. The mountain air is stinging against her suddenly exposed skin, but Catra squeezes Adora's hand, watching their fingers intertwined for several long seconds before she looks up and meets her eyes. Adora's eyes are shining. The look of love on her face takes Catra's breath away. She hasn't seen it in so long. She doesn't know that she has *ever* seen it like this, raw and flushed with excitement. Then again, they have never been standing on the precipice of being Olympic champions together either. Catra's entire body feels like it is thrumming with emotions.

In her periphery, she can see cameras on them. She wasn't really thinking about them, just that she needed proper skin contact with Adora, but she would have thought that they would be distracted with the final runs if she had remembered their existence. Apparently they don't think that Catra or Adora are going to get displaced either and would rather film the medalists. Of course there are plenty of cameras on the ski slope still, but this moment wasn't as private as it felt.

Catra didn't see anything but Adora for a few moments there. She doesn't know if she can bring herself to find that a bad thing. She just fucking *proved* herself after all. She has the gold right now. She is the best skier at the Olympics, even with her busted hand and shoulder. She clings onto Adora, squeezing her hand and pulling it close so she can kiss the back of it. Adora squeaks a little, causing Catra to look up at her even as she kisses her again.

Adora's cheeks are scarlet. Catra opens her mouth, a teasing smirk already curling at her lips as she prepares to speak, but she is cut off by a cheer behind her. When she wasn't paying attention, the last run finished. The score must have just been posted, but that wasn't Team Switzerland cheering – it was USA.

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Catra doesn't cry during the medal ceremony, but it is a damn near thing, though Adora might be the only person who can tell. She breathes heavily, carefully trying to control it and not get emotional as the American anthem plays. Adora can think of no one that she would rather be second to and she says as much to the camera that catches her on the way to the full press conference afterwards. Unfortunately they had to split up pretty quickly, ushered off by their respective teams, but they exchanged looks whenever they could.

"For the love of god, stop kissing her in public until the end of the Games," Adora overheard someone on the American team say to Catra. She turned her head to find Catra already blowing her a kiss. Adora pretended to swoon. There weren't even any cameras around at that moment. Adora doesn't know if the dude was an old-fashioned bigot or more worried about the rivalry between countries, but supposedly the whole point of the Olympics is to promote unity, so honestly he should be telling them to do it more.

She tweets how proud she is of Catra as she makes her way to the press conference and is surprised to find that at:ng Catra's account works. Catra must have unblocked her at some point. Normally Adora just types Catra's name and leaves off her handle, but maybe she was feeling hopeful. She still wasn't expecting it, though. She found ways around the block, but she grins as she sits down at the table. She isn't the only one there, other members of the Canadian ski and snowboard team sitting alongside her, but only one of the

male snowboarders managed to podium as well, so Adora ends up the main focus of attention.

"Adora, this is your first medal for Team Canada. Are you happy with the effort that you put out there today?" one of the female reporters asks. Adora sets the bag of loose POWER BANOLA® that she is snacking on down onto the tablet in front of her – the brand is one of her sponsors, but also she's just starving and it was the closest food – and holds up a finger to indicate that she will answer in a minute. She was really hoping to fly under the radar at first so she could just eat in peace, but her Twitter was already blowing up when she checked it and she knows that people likely have some questions for her.

"I am. I managed to improve on my last Olympics and you really can't complain when you're on the podium. I love having room for growth. Maybe I'll be back for gold in four years," she responds, immediately shoving more granola in her mouth when she finishes speaking. Her relationship with her food sponsors is kind of a meme at this point, but no one can say that she promotes products she doesn't like. She has a few ads with sports equipment companies that she doesn't really use, but that's because they only sell gear aimed towards beginner or casual skiers. She is well past that equipment level now.

Her more lucrative – and more talked about – sponsorships are with food companies. Usually a few of them will send her food right before a competition in hopes that she eats it where a camera can see – and given her appetite, they usually get what they hoped for. Adora needs her calories and she definitely doesn't mind getting paid to eat. Her fans seem to find it endearing, so she doesn't really see any problem with it. Right now it gives her a brief reprieve as the next reporter asks a question of the snowboarder instead while she eats. Once she swallows, though, a reporter pounces on her again.

"You seemed to have a touching reunion with your former teammate after your final run. Would you like to comment on that?" he asks. Adora was expecting the question, but she still doesn't really have

an answer for it. She was shocked at how unguarded Catra was willing to be – not just with her , but in public – and she still doesnt know where exactly their relationship stands. t is undoubtedly rekindling, but it's not a good time to talk to the public about it when it is still in such a fragile place that she doesnt even know what to call it.

"Not really . Moving to Canada didnt magically erase the people I knew in America, is all," Adora replies, shrugging. Her bag of granola is down to crumbs. Dammit. She would love nothing more than to slump down in her chair and eat for the rest of this press conference.

"For a long time you two were regarded as rivals. There are clips online of you two antagonizing each other . What changed?" the reporter presses. Adora groans, dropping her head back in her chair and resting it on the short back. t isnt mature, but she is in her twenties and she never got to have a real childhood, so she can be a bit childish now that she is on her own and there is no one to tell her no. Well, no one but *Catra,* who may get mad at Adora for talking about their relationship. Reluctantly, Adora lifts her head.

"Our relationship isnt anybody's business. We're athletes. We came here to compete, not talk about gossip," Adora replies, sending the reporter a vague glare. She doesnt want to be asshole, but *he* sure is.

"So you're in a relationship?" another reporter pipes up. Luckily , one of Adora's teammates cuts in.

"Anybody have any *relevant* questions?" Perfuma asks beside her . Her biathlon was yesterday , but it was late in the day, so this is her first press conference following it. She didnt place, but she came damn close. Fifth in these games is nothing to be ashamed of. She is worth asking questions of too, the reporters just apparently dont think what she has to say is as juicy . They're wrong: Perfuma will actually *answer* their questions, unlike Adora. There's a moment of silence, a few of the reporters even exchanging looks.

"Grayskull, you mentioned getting a gold. Do you intend to try for the next Winter Olympics?" one pipes up. Adora would prefer that they question someone else, but she breathes a sigh of relief anyway. Finally, they are back on track.

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Catra's team isn't very happy about her fraternizing with a traitor – they aren't super serious when they call Adora that, but Catra is sure that they aren't totally joking either – but Catra doesn't really give a shit what they think. She got her gold medal, fulfilling her personal goal and her "patriotic duty" of racking up Team USA's medal count. Despite the pressures that she put on herself leading up to this and how disappointed she would have been to not podium, she didn't actually *expect* to. She hoped to and she talked a lot of trash, but anything could have happened.

She spends the rest of the day almost in a daze. She doesn't take her medal off after the ceremony and she keeps looking down at it as she is ushered around, shovels down a meal, and finally makes her way back to the Olympic village. She will have interviews tomorrow and she knows that Adora had one tonight – she texts Catra that the reporters were nosy as Catra is eating her dinner – but despite how she isn't looking forward to it, she is riding too much of a high to come down right now.

The clip of her and Adora has made its way online by now and Catra scrolls through the replies to it on Twitter as she lounges around in the common area outside Adora's dorm. The reactions are mixed, but very few people seem to have noticed the weirdness with Catra's hand. The few that have are mostly commenting stuff like "is her hand okay?" She finds one thread correctly speculating that her old injury was giving her trouble, but no one seems to have started a

conspiracy that she has been hiding the effects of it for years. She supposes it isn't really a conspiracy.

It is true, but it isn't the internet's business. It's her hand, her *life*, and she doesn't owe anything to anybody. She was worried about there being a lot of talk about it, but it doesn't seem anyone really gives a shit. They *shouldn't*, it just feels like something that has had such a big impact on her life should matter more – it should take more from her. She glances down at the gold on her chest. For a moment, it almost feels like her heart is beating right against the medal. Even if a sponsor drops her or new ones are turned off from working with her, they can't take *this* from her.

"Hey, Catra," a coy tease cuts into her thoughts. Catra startles, looking up to find Adora sauntering over with a wide smile. Catra, without meaning to, begins purring.

"Hey, Adora," she returns, pushing herself up out of her bean bag. Adora is still dressed in her Team Canada gear and has some snow clinging to her hair from outside, but Catra doesn't hesitate to bound up and wrap her in a tight hug. Adora drops the gear bag that she is carrying, eagerly wrapping her arms around Catra in return and hugging her back. Despite the snow now melting onto her, Catra continues to purr.

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Adora doesn't feel bad for not getting gold. Catra deserves it more than she does - she *needs* it more. She can't complain when Catra is stretched out in her bed in a tank top and leggings, her jacket ditched on the floor and her medal shining on her chest, purring as she watches Adora change into loungewear. The silver medal doesn't match the muscle tee and sweatpants that she pulls on, but Adora likes the weight of it. She cradles it against her chest as she

flops down in the bed beside Catra and cuddles her. Catra happily rubs her cheek against the side of Adora's head.

"I got to watch the full video of your runs. Especially that last one," Catra says, her voice low and touched. Adora grins, turning her head and capturing Catra in a kiss. Catra purrs through it, her tail flicking with excitement as she rolls over to lay on her side so they can face each other.

"Did you like it?" Adora asks, breathlessly , when they part. She can feel warmth in her cheeks, but she's just *excited*. Their runs are done. The medals haven't just been distributed, but are hanging around their necks. Catra hasn't run. She is still here, still in Adora's bed, and still *happy*. Adora lets both her eyes flutter closed as Catra scent marks the side of her face, although that is partially a protective measure to keep Catra's cheek fluff from getting in her eye.

"I loved it," Catra corrects, her voice warm. Adora's heart skips in her chest and she happily leans their heads closer together. Catra clears her throat little. "And you. Still. In case that wasn't clear ," she adds, her voice small and barely above a whisper. The words are like a shot through Adora's heart, causing her to tremble slightly as she presses forward and clumsily presses a kiss against Catra's chin. It is the nearest part of her that Adora can reach. She can't wait long enough to find her mouth. She fumbles down, finding Catra's left hand and twining their fingers together as her heartbeat pounds through her body.

"Yeah?" she asks, breathless and hopeful, but she said it to Catra on the first day and while she didn't think that Catra would have kept going if she didn't still feel at least some of what she used to, she still needs the assurance of hearing it. Catra scoffs lightly, but Adora knows that sound and it's the *I'm trying to cover up my emotions* one. She manages to wriggle her free arm under Catra's waist and pull her close, squeezing their intertwined hands as she does so. Catra is clearly flustered, her ears and tail flicking and her gaze fixed firmly on the ceiling.

"Yeah. Ialways did. Ive been missing you ever since the fight, I just.Ineeded to establish myself until Ifelt like there was no chance of anyone ever discounting me again, Iguess. It was pride, but Ialso Ineeded to have something other than you before Icould risk letting you in again. Icouldnt take losing it all again,"Catra admits, her tone a bit raw and yet begrudging. *Talking* was always Catra's least favorite thing.

Adora lets go of Catra's hand to shift up and cup her face instead, darting her eyes over it to take in all its details. Her expression is raw, her gaze is still fixed on the ceiling and clearly nervous even as she leans her cheek into Adora's touch. After their talk last night, Adora understands – at least as much as she thinks she is capable – what was going on in Catra's head at the time. It is a relief to hear that she still cared the whole time, but Adora kind of knew that after everything that has happened at the games.

"Life was hell after you left, Adora. Iwas a wreck. The only thing that kept me going was spite. Ihad to act like Ihated you for the last few years or Iwould have totally broken down. Istill thought about you holding me on the rough nights,"Catra adds in a whisper . Adora's breath catches in her chest as Catra swallows thickly. She seems on the verge of tears. Gently , Adora tugs on her cheek and directs her to turn her head so that Adora can kiss her. The embrace is soft, a quiet assurance that she understands. Once again, it is only *kind of*, but if Catra says that is what she was doing, then Adora believes her. Maybe she wouldnt have if she said it two weeks ago, but she does now. This is what Catra looks like when her walls come down.

"Are you ready to try again? Idont know that Ican just be your friend anymore when Istill love you like this. Ive spent years wishing that you would let me in again,"Adora asks, her voice soft, when they pull apart just a few inches. Catra' s eyes are wide, tears clinging at the corners, as she gazes back at Adora. After a moment, she reaches up and grabs Adora's wrist, clinging on as a gentle purr returns to the room. Her tail flicks in Adora' s periphery before she leans forward and rubs their cheeks together.

"*Duh*, idiot," she replies. It startles a laugh from Adora. She uses the arm around Catra's back to squeeze her close, tilting her head to give Catra better access for her marks. Adora is more than happy to smell like she is Catra's. Catra's purr rumbles through her chest and into Adora.

"It's going to be hard. If we're going to manage long distance, we'll have to communicate better than we did before – though I'd be happy for us to visit each other all the time, too," Adora adds. She is under no illusions that this magically solves all their issues, but the Catra that she has seen at the games is a totally different one than she came home to four years ago. That girl was *hurt*, broken and shattered in every way. She was hard to love simply because she truly believed that she *couldn't* be.

"I know. But Adora. The only two things that I've wanted for the last four years have been an Olympic medal and *you*," Catra returns, her eyes a bit pleading like she somehow expects Adora to turn her down. Instead, Adora surges forward and kisses her. That is all that she has wanted to hear in years.

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The Closing Ceremonies are a bittersweet affair. Catra is so proud to have gotten her medal and she wears it with pride, but she knows that tomorrow she and Adora will be getting on separate planes to go back to different countries. The last week of the Olympics were as hard as they were blissful – there were tearful conversations and one heated fight between Catra and Glimmer before Adora and Bow managed to intervene – but Catra wouldn't trade them away for anything.

She is trying to be an adult and get along with Adora's friends, but Glimmer apparently hated her a bit for how she acted over the last

few years – go figure, the feeling was mutual – and a fight happening was inevitable. They managed to begrudgingly make up, but Catra doubts that it will be the last. It wasn't too bad though, and Glimmer has given Catra grudging respect for how she has been trolling the people asking personal questions about her and Adora both in person and in interviews since the video of them kissing and holding hands went up.

Catra wants to be able to *keep* holding hands with her. She doesn't want another minute of physical distance between them after the last three weeks have felt like healing. Luckily, she won't have to wait long. They have already begun arranging to go skiing at Whistler together next month. Adora is definitely trying to sway Catra towards the ways of Canadian skiing, but despite the way that she has bristled about Adora's move to Canada for the last few years, Catra isn't opposed. They have already talked about how shitty it was for Adora to just decide to move and expect Catra to get with the program.

It was a while ago and Catra wants Adora back in her life. Their relationship isn't going to work long term if they aren't in the same place, and Adora has an entire career built up in Canada along with a life, friend network, and even house. Catra isn't planning to represent anybody in the next Olympics and she isn't tied to her day job. She can go where the wind takes her , and at this point in her life, she is pretty sure that is going to be right into Adora's arms. She spent too many years alone and bitter already. She knows that Adora isn't interested in coming back to America.

For once, Catra is willing to meet her in the middle. When Adora talks about her new home with love, Catra just wants to be there with her and get to see the joy in her face. As sad as she is to leave the Olympics behind, she can't help but think back to that statistic she read about medal winners. She can't imagine feeling stressed by her gold. It is all that she has wanted aside from Adora. Maybe she is a special case since she knows that she won't be back here again, but she can't imagine changing anything about these Games.

They brought Adora back to her . She cant think of anything else that could matter.

Chapter End Notes

No proper fic notes for this one, so have some rambling:
- Catra visits Canadian ski resorts while Adora visits American ones so they can meet up with each other roughly once a month for a year before Catra applies for a visa and comes up to stay with Adora. Before her VISA runs out they get married. Since Adora is now a Canadian citizen, Catra becomes one too. They live near a smaller ski resort where they ski together a lot, though they also travel for competitions. They almost always enter in the same ones.
- Catra's injury starts coming up more and being harder to hide. If she had a normal job, it really wouldnt be a big deal, but it does start to limit her ability to do twists. She does physical therapy to keep her shoulder limber enough to perform, but she isnt at the top of her game anymore by the time the next Olympics come around. She does get to compete in several major competitions before then though and she is proud of how many years of serious competition she did get out of it. As her injury gets harder to hide, however , she begins to speak out more about disabilities and reveals she was disabled at the time of her Olympic gold medal, which causes a bit of a stir.
- Adora does manage a third Olympics, though she only gets fifth in it. She was still ecstatic to have made it so far. She does a soft retirement like Catra did already: she slowly starts attending fewer competitions, especially the hardest ones, and eases into skiing just for fun like Catra has begun to do. They both still love the sport and sometimes they do things for it still, but professional sport careers are always on time limit due to injury build-up and natural aging.
- Imade POWER BANOLA up but it is kinda real. Adora eating during the press conference is a reference to Chloe Kim, because Meta sent me that video of her asking for snacks from the reporters and it's such a fucking mood.

- I can't remember who said it first, but the food sponsorships thing and Catra trolling Twitter were for Meta. They'll have something posted soon 👀
- Despite how blasé I am about my inaccuracies, I actually did a lot of research for this AU, mostly into the Olympic village, policies for athletes, and skiing in America vs. Canada. I just had trouble finding answers or straight up didn't care about the other stuff 😅
Me: this isn't any particular Olympics.
Also me: literally determines who wins by looking at the Actual Medal List on Wikipedia from 2022. (Neither Canada nor USA podiumed with slopestyle, but America's best medal in the freestyle skiing category was gold while Canada's was silver. Honestly I couldn't decide how I wanted it to go because there were so many options that would have shaped the narrative in different directions, so I used that as my decider).

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